What Takes Hold

Behind that outside pattern the dim shapes get clearer every day. It is always the same shape, only very numerous.

Charlotte Perkins Gilman
"The Yellow Wallpaper" [132]

I. FOR NOW

1. The First Sunday Back

On the first Sunday back, they could eat outside.

The table would have to go across the court rather than along it. There would be arguments about this. Ruth would say it blocked the passage, although she had been the person who suggested it, and somebody would fetch a shorter table that was also lower, so that the two surfaces met at an inconvenient height.

They would put the bread over the join.

Eva would come through Ruth's side gate carrying the glasses in a shallow box on her lap. Ruth would already have moved the watering cans and the sack of compost. The gate would be held open by the flat stone with the white stripe through it, which everyone mistook for a piece of broken paving until they tried to lift it.

Leila would arrive late with a dish she had not made.

"I was going to," she would say.

"Good thing you didn't," Ruth would tell her. "There's nowhere left to put anything."

Nobody would ask whether she was all right. There would be time for that later, or there would not. For once, her arrival would be allowed to remain an arrival.

The sun would be on the fronts of the houses. At the back, the narrow gardens would still be damp. The repair work would have left one cottage a brighter colour than its neighbours, although everyone had been assured it was the same paint.

For the first twenty minutes, somebody would keep saying how strange it was to be back. Then Anwar's daughter would knock over a drink, and the strangeness would become a shortage of cloths.

Eva would want more wine. The bottle would be just beyond a bowl of potatoes, close enough for her to consider reaching for it, far enough away to make the attempt conspicuous. Before she could decide, [214] Ruth would take the bottle and pass it behind two people to someone who would ask whose glass needed filling.

"Mine," Eva would say. "It doesn't need a tour."

She would take a sip of wine. [266]

One of the neighbours would have brought a man nobody knew. He would begin explaining why the temporary accommodation had been such a bad arrangement, and Leila would say that some of it had been quite good.

He would mistake this for politeness.

"No, really," she would say.

The conversation divided. At one end, people were discussing the work still needed on the houses. At the other, someone described a television programme with so little accuracy that everybody else began to doubt they had seen the same thing.

Eva was content to listen. [296]

Later, Ruth brought out strawberries in the blue bowl with the repaired foot. The repair had failed years ago. The bowl stood well enough provided nobody turned it.

They ate until the sun moved off the court. Nobody made a speech. Nobody said that they had come through it stronger.

When the tables were separated, crumbs fell from the join.

—

Eva went back to the paragraph about the glasses.

The box existed. She used it for carrying small things between the kitchen and her worktable. But it was not deep enough to hold the tall glasses safely, and most of those had been on a shelf in the room nearest the fire.

She changed *glasses* to *plates*.

Then she went back again. The first table could not go across the court. The usable gap beside it would be too narrow. She entered the dimensions she remembered and asked for the arrangement to be reconsidered.

The new account put both tables lengthways.

It kept the quarrel about which way they should go. Eva read past it to see whether Ruth still brought the strawberries.

She had supplied the names, the number of houses, the fact that they sometimes ate outside together. She had said that the gathering should not be sentimental, then removed a toast to resilience. The request still stood above it: *a possible first Sunday home*.

On the third evening after the fire, this was the first thing she had read that made the return seem like something more than access to a building.

Her room at the Meridian had two teaspoons, one saucepan and a small refrigerator that clicked before starting. Behind the yellow-rendered pub, the rear studio had been adapted years before. Pat had sent photographs with a tape measure visible in them, and Eva had asked about the route to the dining room rather than accepting the room description on its own.

Most of it worked.

The bathroom door caught unless it was pulled firmly closed. Pat had put it on a list.

Through the window she could see a white van parked beside the kitchen stores. Someone had written CLEAN ME on its rear door and another person had added PLEASE.

She read the Sunday again.

Ruth had once said that the blue bowl was too much trouble for something that held fruit. She had also refused to throw it away.

Eva could remember the feel of the repair under her thumb, though she could not remember when she had last touched it.

The last time they had eaten together, a week before the fire, Ruth had put half her supper in a box before they began. She said the portions were getting larger.

Her phone showed twenty-three unread messages in the residents' group.

Most concerned things that could not be settled that evening. A man had been seen going into the court. Someone had heard the repairs would take six months. Someone else said six weeks. A photograph of a fuse box had been circulated without explanation.

Eva typed:

We need to keep the option of coming back together open.

She read it twice.

Then she added:

I'll put together what we know tomorrow so we're not all being told different things.

Ruth replied almost immediately.

Don't sit up too late. [143]

A moment later:

I mean it.

Eva returned to the account of Sunday. She corrected the time at which the sun left the court. In early summer it would remain on Ruth's wall considerably later.

She left the gate open.

In the drawing saved beneath the account, the gate was a break in the fence. Eva enlarged it until the two sides no longer fitted on

the screen. The space between them remained white. Beside the opening she typed *gate left open*.

She saved a copy of the drawing without the account. The note beside the gate stayed.

—

By nine the following morning, Eva had become a person working in the dining room.

She had not intended this. She had gone through for coffee, bringing her laptop because she was waiting for a file. The table in the bay was the right height, the socket was within reach, and nobody had asked when she would be finished.

Across the road, a man in railway overalls was unlocking a gate. Two children stood beside him in the grave expectation that unlocking the gate would be followed immediately by a train.

Eva opened a catalogue of commercial kitchen fittings.

The client had sent photographs of eleven handles and descriptions of twelve. She had asked which handle was missing. He had replied that they were all in the folder.

She counted them again. In the third photograph a blue sleeve was reflected along the underside of the steel. The photographer had offered to remove it. Eva had asked him not to. Without the blue, the handle looked like a slot cut in the page.

A woman came in with a stack of side plates and looked at the laptop, then at the empty coffee cup.

“Breakfast?” she asked.

“I thought that was included.”

“It is for some of you.”

“Which ones?”

The woman put down the plates.

“That’s what I’m trying to find out.”

They examined two lists. Eva was on both, but with different marks beside her name.

The woman's name was Nessa. She ran breakfast for the restaurant business, which was not the same business as the rooms, although it occupied the same building and most people assumed the distinction was something staff had invented to avoid answering questions.

"I can give you breakfast," she said. "I just need to know where to put it."

"In front of me would be ideal."

Nessa laughed, which relieved Eva more than it should have.

"I'll sort it with Pat. What are you having?"

Eva chose the cooked breakfast. Then, because the menu permitted it, she added mushrooms.

She had spent the previous two mornings eating things she had not particularly wanted because they were available. Choosing mushrooms felt disproportionately successful.

Tom, the late-duty manager, came through carrying a parcel under one arm and a box of batteries in his free hand. He asked Nessa about the label printer, then told Eva somebody was coming to look at the bathroom door.

He had a pale line across one cheek where he had apparently slept on something creased. Eva kept looking at it [215] while he explained that the man was also supposed to inspect a fan.

"Is he good with doors or fans?"

"He's very good at coming on Thursdays."

It was Thursday.

Tom took the parcel into the kitchen. Through the open door she heard him telling someone that no, it was not for the hotel, it was his daughter's, and please could it not be put in the cellar with everything else.

The breakfast arrived.

Eva moved the catalogue to one side. She was halfway through the mushrooms when Leila appeared in the doorway.

Leila waited while a couple carried their coats between tables. Then she came over and sat opposite Eva without taking off her cardigan.

"Have you eaten?"

"No."

"You can have breakfast. There's a list problem, but you can have it."

"I'm not sure I want any."

Eva pushed the toast towards the middle.

Leila took a piece and broke off a corner.

"I need to change rooms," Leila said.

Eva closed the catalogue.

"What's happening?"

"Everything."

Leila had a room in the ground-floor group beneath the pub. At night she heard furniture being moved. Early in the morning there were deliveries, followed by the opening and closing of the service door beside her room. Yesterday she had been told the deliveries were unavoidable.

"They are," Eva said.

"I know. I'm not asking them to stop getting food."

"Did you speak to Pat?"

"I left a message. Then Naomi rang while I was trying to sleep, so I didn't answer. Now I have a message asking whether the room is satisfactory."

Leila put the piece of toast down.

"I can't do another telephone conversation in which I explain that noise isn't a preference."

Eva had known Leila for three years. She knew that Leila had ME, and that knowing this did not tell her what Leila could manage on any particular morning.

"Do you want help writing it?"

"Yes."

Eva opened a fresh document, not the residents' notes.

"Tell me what it needs to say."

Leila spoke slowly. She needed a room away from service activity, not merely a promise that people would try to be quieter. She needed to remain on the ground floor. A smaller room would be acceptable. A room in another hotel might be acceptable, but only after she knew enough about it to decide.

"Don't put that last bit yet," Leila said. "They'll stop looking here."

Eva made a private note rather than including it in the message.

She asked for a short draft containing the first three points.

The suggested wording was clear, but ended with an offer to discuss flexible arrangements.

"Take that out. I've just told them which things I can be flexible about."

They changed *I am finding the room difficult* to *The room is repeatedly preventing me from resting*. Leila added that the problem had continued after she had raised it.

Then she took the laptop and read the whole thing.

"Put 'thank you' at the end," Leila said. "I want it there."

Eva added it.

Leila sent the message from her own phone. For a moment she remained looking at the screen, waiting for a reply. [89]

Then she ate the rest of the toast.

Nessa came over. Leila ordered a boiled egg and another slice. Through a gap between two buildings, Eva showed her the white wall of her own cottage. It looked close until you considered the route to reach it.

For several minutes they ate without discussing the fire.

Eva told her about the missing handle. Leila asked whether the client sold the handles individually or by weight. Eva opened the photographs and showed her. One was clearly the reverse of another, but both had different product numbers.

"Perhaps it's the same handle after something's happened to it," Leila said.

Eva laughed with food in her mouth and had to stop eating.

Tom returned with the parcel now bearing a handwritten name.

He collected a cup from the sideboard. The sleeves of his shirt were rolled unevenly, leaving one wrist bare and the other half-covered. He caught her looking and rolled up the other sleeve. Eva returned to the photographs.

He asked Leila whether she needed anything moved.

"Not yet."

"When you do, let the desk know. Pat's allocating rooms. I'm only the lifting department."

Leila's phone sounded.

Naomi had replied. She had spoken to Pat. A quieter ground-floor room at the rear was becoming available that afternoon, and Pat could show it to Leila before making the change.

Leila read the message aloud, including the part about viewing it.

As she got up, she asked Eva not to put the details of the request in the group document.

"Of course."

"They can know I'm moving rooms. They don't need the explanation."

Eva watched her leave, then reopened the catalogue.

The client had sent another email.

Any progress?

She attached the eleven photographs in a numbered grid and asked him to identify the twelfth.

Then she returned to the menu.

The pastries were extra. She ordered one anyway.

The woman who brought it was wearing one silver earring and feeling for the other.

"Olha," Nessa called. "Your ear."

“I know.”

She put down the plate. The missing earring was caught in the strap of her apron. Eva pointed, and Olha unhooked it carefully.

“You won’t tell her?” [182]

Eva broke the edge of the pastry with her fork. It gave way all at once, scattering flakes over the keyboard.

Outside, the first train was moving out of the station. The children had reappeared at the crossing, making frantic, wholly unembarrassed gestures towards people they had never met.

2. Current Arrangements

Naomi arrived at eleven with a notebook, a phone and folders assembled by several people who had not met. She was coordinating the placements, although the costs and decisions remained with different bodies.

“I can stay until twelve,” she said.

They took a table at the back. [205] Nessa said they could use it until the room was reset for lunch.

There were twelve occupied homes at Sun Court, all former holiday cottages, though some had been extended until the old room was little more than a passage to the newer ones. Seven households were at the Meridian. Ten people were sleeping in the hotel. The others were with relatives, partners or in accommodation elsewhere, except for one man whose whereabouts were known to his sister but not yet to Naomi. She had marked the owners and tenants separately.

Eva opened the document she had begun after breakfast.

She had given it the title *Current Arrangements* because *needs* sounded too comprehensive and *temporary arrangements* suggested a degree of agreement about the duration that nobody possessed.

The first section contained things everybody could know: contact details, meeting times, where deliveries should go, who had keys.

The second was for information people wanted circulated only to particular staff.

The third contained questions.

It was already the longest.

"It will do for a start," [14] Naomi said eventually.

"It has to stay editable."

"Yes."

"And people need to be able to tell you things without telling me."

Naomi took out the sheet for Leila's room change and showed Eva only the room number and the time.

They spent ten minutes resolving practical matters. The kitchen could not store everyone's groceries. One resident needed somewhere cool for an item that should not be left in the communal refrigerator. A parcel had been delivered to Sun Court because somebody's account still defaulted to the old address.

Naomi arranged a delivery point. While she was on the second call, Eva added it to the sheet and heard Naomi read the new line aloud.

Anwar joined them with his daughter's school bag over one shoulder.

"Are we deciding something?"

"Not yet," Eva said.

"Good. I've got nine minutes."

Denise arrived carrying a message from her husband, which turned out to be a question he had already asked in the group. Ruth came in through the front door, saw Naomi and pulled up a chair.

For some residents, the immediate problem was obtaining belongings. For others, it was establishing which authority or insurer was handling a particular cost. Naomi did not pretend these were all part of the same process.

When she reached the intended duration of the hotel placements, the conversation changed.

Nobody had a reliable repair schedule. Three cottages had suffered serious damage. The others could not be occupied until

shared services were safe. Different owners were receiving advice from different people.

“What I need to know,” Naomi said, “is whether I’m holding these placements around an expected return, or whether anyone is asking me to pursue something else.”

“Of course we’re returning,” Ruth said.

Anwar nodded.

Eva looked towards the doorway.

“I think we need to keep that possible.”

“That’s what I mean,” Ruth said.

Anwar had to leave. Before he went, he said they should not let anyone treat the houses as abandoned.

No one seemed to disagree. [250]

Eva typed:

Keep the possibility of a collective return open while repairs and individual circumstances are clarified.

“That sounds reasonable enough,” [269] Naomi said. “But I need a short working position I can put in the accommodation note.”

“Can’t that be it?”

“It can. I’m asking whether return is the preferred plan at the moment.”

“For us,” Ruth said.

Eva knew that *us* meant Ruth and herself. It also appeared to mean everybody at the table.

She gave the drafting window the notes and asked for a short update without adding decisions. When it asked who would read it, she put *residents, accommodation staff, contractors*. She did not make three requests.

The first paragraph read:

The residents intend to return to Sun Court once repairs are complete. Current accommodation should therefore be maintained while access, repair times and individual requirements are confirmed.

She stopped at *intend*.

“It’s a bit definite,” she said.

“I can put ‘currently intend’.”

“We haven’t asked everyone.”

“Then say ‘the residents represented here’.”

“That makes it sound as if we’ve appointed ourselves.”

“We are here,” Ruth said.

Eva did not wish to contradict her. [238] While she was looking for a sentence, Nessa came over to ask whether the remaining plates could be removed.

“We can change it,” Naomi said. “I’m not asking anyone to sign away an option. I need something to work from.”

Keeping the placements together would help. Having the contractors assess the existing arrangements would help. Making clear that the court remained people’s home would help.

She added:

Individual preferences remain subject to confirmation.

They moved on to access for the inspection.

Eva described her existing route: along the side of Ruth’s cottage, through the connecting gate, into her rear entrance. Naomi asked whether it should be treated as the route to use once access to the court was permitted.

“For now,” Eva said.

Ruth was looking at a message on her phone.

Eva added *existing side entrance* to the notes beside her address. She did not write *through Ruth’s garden*. She used the sketch from the Sunday account. The surveyor would see the route, and she did not want the general document explaining everybody’s private arrangements in unnecessary detail.

By five to twelve, they had dates for two inspections, a delivery procedure and a draft account of what they were doing.

“Please send corrections,” Naomi said. “Not just to Eva.”

Denise promised to show the document to her husband. Ruth wanted a printed copy. Anwar sent a thumbs-up when Eva circulated the link.

Leila had not read it. Neither had several people staying elsewhere.

Eva wrote that nobody's silence would be taken as agreement. She put this at the beginning of the message, where it could not easily be missed.

Then she spent half an hour making the document easier to read.

Eva changed the heading *Issues* to *Outstanding questions*.

When she read the result, she decided it would have to do. [235] People had places to stay, dates to attend and named contacts. The gaps were visible rather than dispersed across messages. She sent the updated version. Naomi replied before the end of lunch.

Thank you. I'll ask Pat to hold the seven bookings on this basis and give the surveyor the access information. We can review individual plans after the inspections.

An attachment contained the provisional visit order.

The returners were being seen first, beginning with the route through Ruth's garden. The order let Clare use one morning for the adjoining properties and gave Anwar a time he could get away from work. Eva moved her own appointment to make room for his. The shorter list went to the contractor; the questions stayed in the shared file.

Eva was listed under *Residents returning following repairs*.

She checked her telephone number. It was correct.

Then she went back to the catalogue and discovered that the client had finally acknowledged the missing handle. He wanted the gap left in place because the photograph would arrive shortly.

She left the gap.

That afternoon, Leila changed rooms. Pat showed her the quieter one before the move, and she accepted it. Tom took two bags down the corridor. Leila carried her laptop.

Someone's misplaced parcel arrived. Another resident obtained clothes from the court. Ruth found out when she would be allowed to inspect her garden.

By evening, there were fewer unanswered questions in the group.

They were waiting to go home.

The tables would be lengthways. Denise had asked whether they could eat together when the court reopened, and Eva sent her the drawing rather than the Sunday. Denise knew someone who might lend the second table. She would ask him to keep it aside.

—

Ruth won her first game of pool without taking off her coat. The man she was playing had asked whether she knew the rules. Now he was explaining that the table ran differently from the one he usually used.

His name was Len. He was staying for two nights while his wife watched birds. Ruth kept her own counsel. [2]

He assumed she was visiting the coast. When he asked whether she was having a good time, she said the weather could have been worse. For the second game she took off her coat.

Between shots she straightened and waited for the pull in her back to ease. Before she could decide [214] whether to sit down, it went. Len was still considering his shot.

The bar was almost empty. A cleaner passed through carrying a stack of folded cloths. Outside, people were assembling at the station, facing different directions while waiting for the same thing.

She checked a message from a nursery inland. The cold frame she had ordered before the fire was ready for collection. They could keep it for another fortnight.

She typed *Thank you, I'll let you know* and put the phone away.

She had wanted the cold frame since the previous autumn. It was low enough not to shade the narrow bed, large enough for the seedlings she repeatedly began too early. The proper place for it was against the warm wall beside the gate.

Not in front of the gate.

But close enough that the route through her garden would need reconsidering.

When she had mentioned this in February, Eva had said they should look at the court's rear path. It was an awkward route with a broken section beside the service building. Work would be needed. There were people to ask, estimates to obtain.

Then something else had happened, and February had become March.

Now the service building was blackened and the whole court had become somebody else's problem to schedule.

"Same time tomorrow?" he asked.

"Eleven?"

"Fine by me."

She smiled to herself. [191]

She put her coat back on and went to Eva's studio.

Eva opened the door with a piece of toast in her hand and offered Ruth jam. Ruth said she had eaten, then took some.

Ruth took off her coat again.

The studio was already becoming Eva's. There was a stack of papers in the wrong place, a charging cable laid across an arrangement of objects that prevented it falling, and a cup containing three pens that did not look likely to work.

The bed was made on one side.

Ruth put the printed document on the table.

“Naomi sent the inspection order.”

“I’ve seen it.”

“They’re coming to mine first.”

“They’re doing the access route.”

“That’s what I wanted to talk about.”

Eva put down the toast.

“I don’t want the gate assumed.”

Eva looked at the document. They had already discussed getting the shared rear path done. The route through Ruth’s garden was the route there was.

Eva turned the paper towards herself.

Beside her address was a note saying access could be restored through the existing side entrance, subject to the inspection.

“It doesn’t say permanently.”

“It doesn’t say it’s through my garden.”

“There’s a sketch.”

“Not on this.”

“This is the general sheet.”

Ruth sat down.

They had been separated for ten years. There were people at Sun Court who had never known them as a couple, and people who continued to behave as though the distinction was a private eccentricity.

The opening in the fence was older than the separation. At first it had saved them going round to the front. Later the gate had been widened and the paving altered. Eva’s house had acquired a different entrance in practice, though nothing on the street suggested it.

After they separated, they had discussed the gate once.

Ruth had said it could stay.

She had meant it.

Eva picked up the toast, then put it down again.

“Are you saying I can’t use it when we go back?”

"No," Ruth said. "I want them to look at making the other route usable while they're doing the work. Not put everything back as it was and then tell us there's no reason to change it."

"I want that too."

"Then why isn't it here?"

"Because we were trying to get access for an inspection, Ruth. Not redesign the whole court in the dining room."

"I'm asking for a path."

"And I'm trying to get us back into the houses."

"Sometimes," Ruth said, "I want to put something in my own garden without having to measure the space beside it."

For a moment neither spoke. [242]

"That isn't the same as wanting you stuck in your house."

"I didn't say it was."

"You were getting close."

Outside, a vehicle reversed into the rear parking area. Its warning sound repeated while somebody gave instructions that did not appear to help.

Eva moved the document away from the edge of the table.

"What are you putting there?"

"A cold frame. The one I showed you. I ordered it before." Ruth heard herself making excuses. [119]

Eva opened the file.

"What do you want it to say?"

"I don't know. That the existing route is a temporary arrangement. That the shared route needs assessing."

"It's been there eighteen years."

"I remember it well enough." [93]

"Not temporary," Eva said after a moment. "That makes it sound as if it only started with the fire."

She typed another version and turned the screen.

Current access is through an agreed route across the neighbouring property. The inspection should also assess an independent route from the shared court.

"Does independent mean you have to do everything yourself?"

"No. It means not through your garden."

Eva sent the amendment to Naomi and copied Ruth.

Added to the surveyor's questions. Thanks for clarifying.

—

After Ruth left, Eva opened the account of the first Sunday back.

The tables were still lengthways. The plates were still balanced in the shallow box. Ruth had already moved the watering cans and the compost.

Eva selected that sentence. She had read it several times without wanting to change it.

She removed Ruth from the sentence. The watering cans had been moved; the gate stood open. At the table Ruth was still laughing at something said before Eva came through.

Eva asked for the passage to use the amended access description and leave the rest alone. The route became longer. Her arrival took the same sentence.

A message arrived from Leila.

Are you busy?

Eva began to write *Not particularly*, looked at the catalogue waiting behind the other windows, and changed it to *What do you need?*

Leila asked whether she could come over.

Leila arrived carrying her phone and the folded map Naomi had left with her. She had slept in the quieter room. She sat on the chair Ruth had used.

"There's a flat."

Eva waited.

"In Halden. Naomi mentioned it before, but I didn't know whether it was a real possibility or just something she had to mention."

"And?"

"It's available to look at."

Leila handed her the phone.

The photographs were unremarkable: a small sitting room, a kitchen with a window above the sink, a bedroom photographed from an angle that made its proportions difficult to judge.

Leila unfolded the map. She had drawn a route in pencil and written a distance beside it.

The flat was not by the sea. It did not have a view worth photographing. It had a separate bedroom, reliable-looking heating and nobody else's front door immediately outside its own.

Leila described where she might put the chair she used for reading. There was room for it away from the bed. She would not have to clear it whenever she needed to reach the wardrobe.

"I haven't made up my mind. [329] I'd like to see that," [223] she said.

"You can look without deciding."

"That's what I thought. But the appointment they've sent me is about what I need while I'm waiting to return."

Eva looked towards the document on her laptop.

Leila followed her glance.

"I know you said we could change it."

"We can."

"I'd like to look before it becomes a discussion about whether I'm leaving."

"Of course."

Leila refolded the map, less neatly than it had been folded before.

"Would you come with me?"

"Yes," Eva said.

Leila took back her phone and opened the message with the available times.

Eva opened her calendar.

3. The Other Route

The chair fitted beside the window after all.

For the first fortnight Leila had kept it facing into the room. Then, on an afternoon when she was able to move it, she turned it a little towards the glass. From there she could see the upper branches of a tree and a section of the building opposite. Someone had a red towel over their balcony rail. It was still there. [261]

Eva came on a Thursday with soup in a container that leaked inside the bag.

“Keep it upright,” Leila said. Eva lifted the bag a little higher.

Leila fetched a bowl. Eva held the bag over it while she cut the corner away with scissors. A little soup went onto the television remote. Eva wiped it with her sleeve before Leila saw.

They ate with the television on and the sound off. There were people standing beside a swimming pool, all talking at once. [164] From time to time one of them looked into the water.

Leila had meant to ask about Sun Court. Instead they discussed whether the woman in the yellow dress had brought another pair of shoes. The programme did not tell them.

After they had eaten, Leila lay down in the bedroom. Eva stayed in the sitting room, answering a message from a client. The door between them was open. Once, Eva asked where the spare charger was, and Leila said beside the biscuit tin. For a while she listened to the keys. When the typing stopped she did not ask whether Eva was still there.

She woke with the uncomfortable impression that somebody had spoken to her. There was only the sound of water in the kitchen. She stayed in bed until she could get up without having to stop halfway.

Eva had rinsed the bowls and was reading the book from the chair.

“You’ve lost my place.”

“There’s a receipt in it.”

“That’s an old place.”

Eva turned back a few pages. Leila recognised a paragraph and said that was near enough.

Outside, a bus stopped beyond the tree. Its lit upper windows moved slowly across the room. Eva checked the time but did not begin putting everything away.

There was another bus after this one.

—

On Monday the chair was still at Sun Court. Graham had been told he could retrieve it during the next supervised visit, provided somebody could show him which room it was in. Leila sent him a photograph and asked him to leave the folded curtain beneath the damaged arm.

She had sent Eva the evening on Sunday night. Eva read it again while they waited beside the Meridian’s rear door for the booked car.

“You’ve made me bring soup.”

“You were cooking something. I changed it. I couldn’t bear to explain.” [123]

A kitchen worker came out with a sack of empty containers. Leila moved aside, then stayed beside the wall, where she could lean without making a separate arrangement to sit.

“The bus is wrong,” she said. “Not wrong. It goes there, but the later one stops across the main road. I checked the crossing.”

Beneath the evening she had put the actual services, two taxi numbers and a note about the stop. Eva went back to the paragraph in which she remained beside the window. Enough room to turn. [177] She had not yet looked at the taxi prices.

Their Thursday required two rooms.

The car arrived. While the driver secured Eva's chair, Leila stood with one hand on the door frame. Getting ready had used most of the morning she had expected to spend on the viewing. She asked the driver not to turn the radio on.

They left Merewick by the road behind the sea defences. A strip of water appeared between two low roofs, then vanished behind a yard of stacked fencing. Further out, the nuclear buildings stood beyond the scattered houses, too large to look as far away as they were. The site was being dismantled on a schedule that extended beyond any repair anyone at Sun Court had been promised. A white trailer had been placed beside a bungalow whose original front room now appeared to be a porch.

Helen, the housing officer, was waiting outside the building with a ring of keys and a paper cup. She had expected them ten minutes later and seemed pleased by the prospect of recovering ten minutes, until Leila said she would need to sit before they began.

Helen unlocked the communal entrance. There was a powered opener, its button partly obscured by a notice about not admitting people they did not know. She went back to her car for a folding chair while Eva and Leila waited inside.

The flat smelled faintly of fresh paint and a cleaning product Leila could not identify. Helen opened the chair. It made a hard sound in the empty room. Leila sat down.

Helen began with the heating controls, then stopped when Leila closed her eyes. She left the instructions on the kitchen surface and said she would make a call outside.

The tree was there. So was the building opposite. There was no red towel.

After a few minutes Leila asked Eva to open the bedroom door. From the chair she could see a strip of carpet, the edge of the window and part of a fence outside. There was a dark rectangle on the skirting where a piece of furniture had stood. Nothing needed moving before she could go in.

When Helen returned, she switched on the extractor to show that it worked. Leila asked her to turn it off. In the silence afterwards water ran somewhere in the block. A door closed. Leila asked to come back when people were home from work.

Helen checked her diary. Wednesday at four thirty was possible.

Eva measured the space beside the window. The green chair would fit, though not at quite the angle Leila had given it. The photographs and dimensions had been the easiest things to supply. Leila had spent longer getting rid of an account in which she stayed up throughout the visit.

“How often does your visitor come?” Helen asked.

Leila looked towards Eva.

“I’m asking about space,” Helen said. She had the short note Leila had sent about needing somewhere to rest while someone stayed.

“Not often enough yet,” Leila said.

Eva kept the end of the tape against the wall. She had been going to say they hadn’t arranged anything.

Helen showed them the rubbish store. The route was longer than it appeared from the window, around the planted strip and through another door. She wrote down Leila’s question about help taking things out. They went back through the flat, where Eva tried the bathroom doorway. She could enter, but the position of the basin made the turn awkward.

“Could the door come off?” she asked.

Helen looked at the hinges.

“Not for you coming round,” Leila said.

“I didn’t mean—”

“I need the door.”

Eva backed out. She had meant to suggest reversing the door. Helen was waiting with her pen, and Leila had returned to the folding chair. Eva put the tape measure in her bag.

—

On the return journey, Leila slept with her coat between her head and the window. Eva’s phone kept lighting up. Someone wanted to know whether the inspection included the inside of his loft. Another resident had sent a photograph of a bill, with the account number visible to everyone.

They passed a short row of shops in Halden. One had an awning pulled out over trays of plants; another had three copying machines visible through its window. Beside the print shop was the recessed entrance to some flats. A letting board stood against the brickwork rather than over the door. Eva saw the words GROUND FLOOR before a bus came between her and the pavement.

At the hotel she checked the advertisement. Alder Road. Two bedrooms, one very small. A shallow ramp led from a shared courtyard to the rear entrance. She enlarged the bathroom photograph. There was no useful view of the approach to the shower.

She saved it beside the details of Leila’s flat.

The saved search asked for a minimum number of bedrooms. Eva chose two. One would be for the table. Before she went to sleep she had stopped calling it the second bedroom even in the notes she kept for herself.

Ruth arrived with a bag from the retrieval visit: a charger, unopened envelopes, a cardigan and the shallow box.

“The plates are all right,” she said. “I had a look.”

Eva thanked her. Ruth asked about Leila’s place.

“Does she like it?”

Eva said she thought so. She described the kitchen and separate bedroom, then found herself describing the bathroom as if she were going to live there. [127]

That night Eva put the Alder Road particulars into the writing window. She added the work she did, the measurements of her chair, the furniture she would keep. She wrote that the cost had to include leaving Sun Court, not retaining it as somewhere to return to. She was not asking for a holiday.

The account began with moving boxes. She deleted the first page.

—

By the end of the first month she had stopped keeping the hall clear of things that were not there.

There was room for a bag beside the door and still room to turn. The spare wheel went into the small bedroom with the worktable. She had considered putting the table in the sitting room, then discovered that she wanted to close a door on a page she had not finished. On the first Friday she closed it at four. At half past four she went back for the charger and checked something, but she did not sit down.

The woman upstairs had the second key to the bin store. Eva asked her about a catch that needed lifting at the same time as the handle was turned. The woman showed her how she did it, watched Eva try, and said she would report it too. Until it was repaired they arranged for the woman to leave the inner gate on its hook on collection mornings. Once she forgot. Eva rang her bell.

There was a great deal to learn. [311] The shop sold coriander on Tuesdays and often had none by Wednesday. The pavement outside the hairdresser collected water even when the rain had

stopped. At the print shop a man called Kit listened to her problem with a colour proof and brought out a sheet he had been keeping to prove the same point to someone else. The red on his sheet was better. She had to admit it. [50]

A week later she came again. [56] They talked for long enough that he had to serve two customers while she was still there. She bought a packet of envelopes she did not need.

Leila lived close enough that a visit did not have to last long enough to justify the journey. One morning Eva took her a charger and went home before the kettle boiled. On another they spent forty minutes choosing a film and never watched it. Leila had a bad fortnight in which Eva left two bags outside her door and spoke to her once. Afterwards Leila asked what had happened to the film. Eva could not remember its name.

Ruth came on a Saturday with cuttings wrapped in damp newspaper. She walked through the flat slowly, opening one cupboard after asking and another without. She did not like the kitchen surface. Eva did not like it either. The landlord had agreed to the removable section beneath the sink but not to changing the whole kitchen, and the join collected crumbs.

They went out for lunch. Ruth wanted to see the shops and spent a long time choosing a present for her sister. At Sun Court she would have said she needed to get back to water something. Here she had watered before leaving.

When she went home, she forgot the bag containing the pots. Eva put it beside the door, where it remained for three weeks. There was still room to turn.

In the evening Eva opened the window. The room smelled of warm brick and food from somewhere down the street. She heard a train beyond the roofs, larger than the trains opposite the Meridian and too far away to see. Tom rang from the bar. They talked until somebody needed him. She stayed by the open

window after the call, pleased to be left to herself, [297] listening to the street while she finished her drink.

—

Wednesday's second viewing lasted thirty-five minutes. A television was audible from the next flat. Someone upstairs came home, walked from one end of the building to the other and ran water for a long time. Leila asked Helen to leave her alone in the bedroom for a while.

Eva stayed in the sitting room. She had booked the accessible taxi for six, allowing time to look at the route from the bus stop. Leila had wanted to check it herself rather than rely on the screen.

When Leila came out of the bedroom she said, "I want it." Helen wrote down the next step and the date.

Leila put the paper in her bag. The heating question had been answered. There was a number to call about help with the rubbish, but no arrangement yet.

At five twenty she needed to leave.

Eva rang the taxi company. The booked driver could not come early. They waited in the flat rather than go to the bus stop. Helen delayed her next appointment and brought the folding chair nearer the bedroom door.

While they waited, the Alder Road agent replied. The flat was still available. She attached a floor plan with several measurements missing and asked whether Eva wanted to view it.

On the plan the workroom was labelled BED 2.

Eva enlarged the workroom. The door opened against the wall where she had put the shelves.

The taxi arrived at six. They reached the Meridian after Leila had stopped answering questions except by nodding. Eva helped carry the bag to Leila's room, then sat outside her own door while the driver corrected an error on the card machine. The fare was

more than she had expected. The evening beside the window would cost this much each time unless they found another way.

Graham had sent a photograph. He had secured a space for the green chair in his lock-up until the keys were ready. A folded card on its seat said HALDEN.

Leila's reply came much later.

Thank you. Don't lose the curtain.

—

Ruth had expected to recognise the smell of the fire. What she recognised first was the smell of her garden after rain.

The blackened service building stood beyond the fence. A length of guttering had curled away from its brackets. Someone had stacked the undamaged bins against the end cottage. Her pots were where she had left them, except for one that had fallen on its side. [5] The soil beneath it was dry.

Graham was waiting beside his van with two long gate hinges wrapped in clear plastic.

"Got these through a mate. Better than what's on there." Ruth made no move to take them. [334] Graham said there was no harm having them.

She did not want the hinges. She wanted the gate left alone long enough for someone to consider not using it. Graham put them back in the van before she could say so. [10] He had also brought a board for the rough paving near the entrance, which Eva would need when she arrived. Ruth helped him lay it flat.

Clare, the surveyor, came with a younger man who carried a measuring wheel. Three people answered when she asked who owned the service building. The question of who held the keys was easier to settle.

Eva arrived with Naomi. Graham kept his boot on one corner of the board until she was across, then lifted it out of the way of the next person.

Clare had a printed plan with the existing route marked in red. It passed down the side of Ruth’s cottage, through the garden and into Eva’s rear entrance. Beside the opening it said *gate left open*. The amendment was on another sheet. The papers were different sizes and could not be laid over each other without obscuring something.

Eva recognised the words beside the gate. They were hers.

Before anyone arrived, Ruth had moved the watering cans to the wall and wedged the gate with the flat stone. She wished she had left the cans where they were. Now the route looked effortless, a stretch of clear paving that happened to pass her door.

Clare measured the gate and the space beyond it. She asked Eva to show her the turn, then to repeat it while she stood elsewhere. It was a movement Ruth had watched thousands of times without needing to describe it. She found herself holding her own hands out of the way, although she was standing well back.

Inside, Eva’s kitchen was largely untouched. The shared power was off, and the absence of the refrigerator’s sound made the room feel temporarily larger. A cup stood upside down on a towel. [103] There were three onions in the wire basket, one with a pale shoot folded against the wall.

Clare asked about the lowered work surface and the space beneath the sink. Eva showed her where the plumbing had been moved. She explained why a replacement door must not open the other way, then asked the younger man to hold the tape while she checked a measurement he had written down.

When they had finished, Eva asked Ruth to look in the back of a drawer for the smaller stapler.

“Under the tea towels,” Eva said. “Nobody ever looks there.”

Ruth found it beside a packet of seeds she had given Eva two years before. She put the seeds in her pocket.

Outside, Graham had cleared loose material from the shared rear passage. One cottage had a low timber store projecting into it.

Further along, the paving dropped where water had undermined an old repair.

Eva came as far as the broken section. Graham crouched and scraped grit from the edge with a screwdriver. He thought the drain was blocked. Clare asked where it led. He went to fetch a longer tool.

A new opening could be made in the fence. The projecting store could be removed if its owner agreed. The levels needed measuring and the drainage investigating. Clare asked Eva how she would approach the door. Eva described the turn, then asked the younger man to hold the measuring wheel where a gatepost might stand.

“Further over. No, back a little.”

Ruth picked up a loose piece of batten and laid it on the ground [36] for the other side. They tried the turn on the sound section of paving. The wheel stood for one post and the batten for another. Graham returned with a drain rod and waited while Eva backed out.

On the second attempt Eva came round without stopping, hands briefly resting as the chair straightened. Clare watched where the footplates passed the batten. The younger man put two small yellow marks on the paving.

Ruth could already see the cold frame against her wall. She looked at Eva, who was looking back towards the open kitchen door.

“I want this done,” Eva said. “I’m coming back.”

“Good,” Ruth said.

Naomi could put the proposal forward, but she could not authorise the costs. The survey work could be priced now. The drainage might affect everything else.

Graham looked towards the hotel roof above the cottages.

“They find the money when they want to. All those hotels. People turn up and there’s a room. You’ve lived here years and we’re counting paving slabs.”

“The paving still needs counting,” Eva said.

“You know what I’m saying.”

“I’m not agreeing with you.”

Graham turned the rod in his hands. Ruth asked where he thought the pipe ran. She wished she had said nothing. [4] Clare joined them, and for a while they were looking at the same thing.

—

By evening the new entrance had appeared in three photographs.

In the first, the measuring wheel was still standing where the post would go. The younger surveyor had sent it to the owner of the timber store to establish what would need moving. The owner forwarded it to Denise. In the version she sent to the residents, someone had drawn a thicker line between the yellow marks and written NEW ACCESS.

Eva wrote that the costs were not known and the route had not been approved.

Ruth rang the nursery, paid the balance on the cold frame and sent the dimensions to her sister, who had agreed to store it. Her sister rang back. She had thought Ruth meant the size of a coffee table. There was a pause when Ruth said she had paid. Then her sister said she would do her best. [13]

The new entrance required the timber store to come down. Its owner had been wanting to replace it for years. After looking at the photograph he asked Graham to dismantle it during the next supervised visit. Graham agreed. He could put the contents in his lock-up for a fortnight, alongside Leila’s chair, and keep anything useful from the old timber.

Ruth saw the messages the following morning. She sent a thumbs-up, then rang her sister to tell her what had happened. [178]

—

On Monday Naomi brought the inspection summary to the hotel. The shared route was an option requiring further investigation. Existing access remained through the neighbouring property, by agreement.

“But they’ve taken the store down,” Ruth said.

“I didn’t ask them to.”

“I know you didn’t. It’s down.”

Naomi corrected a measurement Eva had found on the drawing. She had obtained permission for a drainage investigation on Thursday. It would cost money. [66]

The cleared passage now held the store’s concrete base, four exposed fixing bolts and a strip of pale wood along the wall it had sheltered. The dismantled panels were at Graham’s yard. He had cut the largest one to get it into the van. He would send photographs if they needed them.

Naomi asked which version of the drawing Graham had. No one knew which one. [260] Eva sent the corrected one. He replied asking when the tools could come out of his lock-up. He had agreed to store a kitchen there the following month.

—

For two days Ruth’s sister kept the cold frame in the garage. Then her husband needed to bring the car inside to work on it. The cartons were carried into the spare room, where one projected far enough beyond the bed to prevent the door closing.

Ruth went over on Tuesday. They opened the long carton and took out the glazed lid, then spent half an hour trying to put it back without trapping the corners against the packing. The lid was heavier than Ruth remembered from the nursery.

Her sister stood it against the wardrobe and put a cushion in front of it.

“It can stay until the end of the month. After that we need the room.”

“I thought you said—”

“I didn’t know how big it was.”

Ruth stopped. On the way back she priced a storage unit on her phone. The smallest one was larger than she needed. The price did not include collecting the cartons.

At the Meridian, Eva was in the dining room trying to resolve a delivery for somebody else. The table in the bay was occupied by a family with railway tickets, so her laptop was on a smaller table near the kitchen. There was no room for Ruth to put her bag down without moving a chair.

“I can’t store it there indefinitely,” Ruth said.

Eva looked up.

“The cold frame.”

“I didn’t know that was a problem.”

“It wasn’t. It is now.”

Eva finished the message she was writing. Ruth waited for an answer. [357]

“Could it go in your garden in the cartons?”

“Not with people going through.”

“I can still use the gate if they’re against the other wall.”

“And when it rains?”

Eva moved the laptop. She had put the stapler beside it. Ruth had not seen it since the visit to the house.

“We could ask Graham about a cover.”

“He’s got enough of our things.”

“And I can’t think what else to say.” [38]

Ruth sat down. She wanted the garden back. She wanted to be able to put the cold frame where she had chosen and discover that she had chosen badly, if that was what happened. Instead it was lying against her sister’s wardrobe, making her brother-in-law apologise every time he went in for a shirt.

Eva's phone sounded. She turned it face down without reading it.

"I liked being in my kitchen," she said.

"I knew you did." [45]

"I want to go there again without six people."

Ruth took the seeds from her bag. The packet had opened at one corner. There were several loose seeds in the lining, too small to retrieve easily. She put the packet on the table.

Nessa came through with a delivery note and asked Eva whether the boxes arriving on Friday belonged to the court. Ruth moved the packet aside. Eva looked at the note. They were replacement worktops for somebody else, sent to the hotel because it was the address now printed beside all the residents' names.

"They can't come here," Nessa said. "We've got a dining room."

Eva reached for her phone. Before she could dial, Ruth's sister rang. Ruth stepped towards the window to answer. Behind the family taking photographs, a train began to move, its passengers waving towards the hotel. Her sister was saying something about the glass. Ruth asked her to say it again.

4. A Working Thursday

The vacancy Tom had found was with a contractor at the nuclear site: buildings maintenance, daytime hours, with some weekend duties. Most of the first page concerned things he could do. The second concerned things he would need someone to decide he could do.

He had started the application on his phone between eleven and midnight, abandoned it when a guest reported a smell of burning, and returned to find the page had timed out. The smell had been a hairdryer. It had still needed checking.

On Friday afternoon he took his laptop into the dining room before his shift. Eva was working at the bay table. He asked whether the socket beside her was free.

For twenty minutes they worked without speaking. Tom had written a list of jobs he did at the hotel and asked the drafting system to organise it under the application's headings. The result was better than the list. It separated things he had repaired from things he had identified and passed to someone qualified to repair them. He had not thought of this before. [319]

Under one heading he added the dates of a course he had taken years before. Under another he removed an example he could not explain if asked. He changed *managed* to *checked* in two places. Then he put *managed* back in the first one. He had been responsible for that job, including finding someone else when the original contractor stopped answering.

The man in the application coordinated repairs. Tom looked at the call log on his phone: the unanswered calls, the second electrician, the evening he had stayed because nobody else knew

which rooms had lost power. *Coordinated* was a word he could use for that. He put it in the answer he was saving to practise aloud.

Eva pushed her laptop away.

He told her about the vacancy. It meant days, mostly. He could be home at four.

It was a little after three. At five he would put his laptop away and go to work.

He asked whether she would read a paragraph. It described finding a leak, isolating the immediate problem and arranging repairs without closing all the rooms. Eva asked what he had actually done first.

"Moved a guest."

"Why did you leave it out?" [243]

"I was trying to make it about maintenance."

"Wasn't it?"

He put it in. The guest had been angry because the new room overlooked the stores rather than the station.

"She said she'd paid for a moving view."

"What did you say?"

"Nothing useful. The bin lorry was out there."

Eva laughed. He gave her the woman's drawn-out way of saying moving, then stopped and read his paragraph again. She waited for him to do the voice once more.

His phone vibrated. A voice message from his cousin Sami was followed by a photograph, then another message asking him to ignore the photograph because it was the wrong one.

Sami was in Gaza. Tom had grown up a few streets from the Meridian; visits to his father's Palestinian family belonged to school holidays and the gaps between jobs. For several days he and Sami had been trying to get a replacement phone to work after the old screen failed. Tom's instructions arrived after someone nearby had tried something else. The photograph showed a

settings menu. In the screen's reflection he could see part of a hand and a strip of bright sky.

The last message asked whether Tom's daughter still wanted to do the course in Bristol. He sent back the next step, asked whether Sami still had the verification code, and said she currently wanted to do three courses in three different places.

He told Eva where his cousin was. She set down her cup [268] and asked where Sami was staying.

"With his wife's sister. They had to move again last week."

Tom waited for another message, then put the phone face down. Eva returned to the application. He was grateful that she had asked about Sami. He was also glad not to explain the photograph, the people whose names she did not know, or why he was sitting here trying to make his work history fit six boxes.

They finished at twenty past four. He submitted the application and received an acknowledgement before he had unplugged the laptop.

"Does Pat know?" Eva asked.

"I'll tell her today."

"Would you take it?" [306]

"If they offer it, I'm taking it."

She looked down at his hands [255] while he wound the lead. He liked that she did not immediately tell him the hotel would be sorry to lose him.

—

Pat agreed to be his referee. Then she asked about the rota.

"I haven't got an interview yet."

"I know. I'm asking how much notice you think they'll want."

He hesitated for a moment. [271] She looked at the wall calendar. There was a Saturday in the following month which neither of them wanted to work.

Pat asked whether he could show Nessa's niece the booking system on Tuesday. The niece already covered occasional bar shifts. Two paid hours at the desk would not make her able to do his job, but it would mean someone else could change a booking without ringing him.

Tom agreed. He had been asking for this for months.

His replacement arrived on Tuesday with a notebook. Before she had learned how to move a guest between rooms, she wrote her telephone number on the staff sheet and asked which Thursday evenings she should keep free.

Laura asked what happened when someone arrived after the restaurant had shut. Tom showed her where the spare menus were. She wrote a number beside the question and asked whether she should ring him if she couldn't find them.

"Ring the desk," he said, then laughed. "You'll be at the desk."

She crossed out his number slowly. He had not been offered anything. On the rota, however, Pat had put a line through one of his Thursdays and written Laura, with Tom beside it.

—

The photograph of the Meridian had appeared on Friday, while Tom was finishing his application.

A guest brought it to the desk that evening. He held his phone as though Tom might have to repair it.

"Is this you?"

The hotel had been photographed from across the road. A service vehicle obscured the rear entrance. Eva was near the corner, with Naomi beside her. Above the picture someone had written that the hotel was no longer taking ordinary guests because it had been requisitioned for migrants.

The man had arrived that morning with his wife and a booking made several weeks before.

"We're guests," he said. "So it can't be right."

“No.”

He stood at the desk. [189]

“Those people are from the fire, aren’t they?”

“Some of the people staying here were displaced by a local fire.”

“That’s what I said.” [281]

Tom asked him to send the post to the hotel’s email address. He did not ask what else he had said.

By half past six Pat had put a correction on the hotel’s page. They were open for bookings. Some rooms were providing temporary accommodation to households displaced from Sun Court. She did not include names or photographs of the residents.

At seven a caller asked how much the hotel was being paid per person. At seven ten somebody wanted to know whether their anniversary booking was still valid. At seven twenty Graham came in and said he had set the matter straight.

“They’re local people. I’ve told them.”

Tom showed him Pat’s statement.

“People need to know the difference,” Graham said.

A couple came through from the station and asked whether the kitchen was still serving. Nessa called that it was, provided they ordered now. Tom found menus. Graham stayed at the counter, scrolling through the comments and occasionally reading one aloud until Pat asked him to stop.

The anniversary booking remained. One family cancelled after saying they had seen the photograph. Another booking was cancelled without a reason. A woman rang to ask whether the resident visible in the picture was the woman who had organised a local collection two winters earlier. Tom said he would not identify a guest.

“She’s not a guest, then. She lives there.”

He repeated that he would not identify her. The woman hung up before he had finished.

On Saturday somebody came round to the rear door to film. They left when Pat asked them to, but by then two residents had gone outside to see what was happening. Pat told staff to keep the door closed. Deliveries were to ring. Guests had been able to come and go through it during the day; now a card was needed, and the reader was high on the narrow strip beside the frame.

Eva could reach it, but not from a position in which she could also manage the door before it locked again. On Sunday she waited eleven minutes for someone to answer the bell. Tom was not on duty. Nessa came through with wet hands and let her in, leaving a mark on the glass.

Pat ordered a second reader to be fitted lower down and a longer release time. Until it arrived, everyone at the desk was supposed to carry the portable bell receiver. On Monday the receiver was left charging in the office. Eva rang the hotel from outside and was put through to the restaurant.

—

The first kiss had been before the door was kept shut.

Eva came through after the dining room closed. Tom was collecting menus near the entrance.

“I saw the post,” she said.

He put the menus on the sideboard. She told him she would rather not be in the photograph. They had reported it, but it was still there.

He did not answer at once. [163]

“I finish in ten minutes.”

“Have you really finished?” [88]

“Pat’s here.”

Eva stayed while he checked the desk and put a set of keys in the office. He returned without the pen he usually carried clipped to his shirt. They went outside. Across the road someone tried twice to close a metal gate at the station.

Tom sat on the low wall beside the stores. Eva turned so neither of them had to face the service door. He showed her a photograph his daughter had taken of him against the yellow wall. He had tried to stop smiling halfway through it. One corner of his mouth had refused. Eva enlarged the picture until most of the wall was gone.

"I like it the way it is." [148]

"You can see every—"

He stopped. She had lowered the phone. There was a small pale scar at the edge of his upper lip which the photograph had missed.

The kiss began awkwardly because he misjudged the distance from the wall. Eva took his shirt between two fingers and brought him closer. Afterwards he stayed beside her, one hand on the cold brick.

"I didn't know what you would say," [300] he said. "Would you like to have dinner?"

"Yes," Eva said.

They chose somewhere he did not work. Thursday was possible if Pat could move a shift. Eva had a deadline on Wednesday and said she would be bad company until it was finished.

He kissed her again. She had moved nearer the wall this time. They stayed there until a delivery vehicle came into the yard and the driver asked whether somebody could show him where to put six boxes of napkins.

—

On Thursday he came at six, carrying a bag from a shop he had passed on the way home from work.

The new path was still pale. Rain had washed grit towards the edge, and he rubbed his shoes on the mat twice before coming in. The gate had a latch Eva could use from either side. Ruth had shut the older gate through her garden. Above it the lid of the cold frame stood open on its prop.

Eva had moved the worktable away from the window. A little more room to move, [206] although she still reached for things where they had been before. Tom put the bag down in the wrong place and she asked him to move it. He did. He fetched the plates without asking.

He had bought too much bread.

“It looked smaller in the shop.”

“It’s a loaf, Tom.”

“I know what it is.”

They ate with the back door open. Somewhere beyond the fence Ruth was moving pots. He asked whether she would want some bread, and Eva said to ask her.

He went out through the new gate and round to Ruth’s front door. When he came back he was carrying two courgettes and a screwdriver Ruth thought belonged to Eva.

“It doesn’t.”

“I’m not taking it back. She was very definite.”

He told Eva about a ceiling at work which had been opened in the wrong place. She tried to follow the relation between the two rooms and the pipe until he fetched a pencil and drew on the back of a circular from the insurers. Halfway through the explanation he began laughing. They laughed a little together, quietly. [283]

Afterwards he washed the pan. She watched him turn the handle inwards without being asked. It was something she had explained on another evening. There were now other evenings to refer to.

Later he fell asleep while she finished a page proof. When she woke him he apologised and asked the time.

“Half past nine.”

He made no move to leave. [356] She asked whether he wanted to stay. He said yes, and then they had to find somewhere to put the clothes on the other side of the bed. He folded a shirt which she had been meaning to wash and she told him not that one.

The laptop remained open in the kitchen. The next morning she would discover that she had sent the earlier version of the proof. For now the bedroom window was open and she could hear Tom moving about behind her, putting things down in a room he was still learning.

By the third Thursday he had a drawer. It was the shallow one which caught if opened too far. Eva had emptied it after he left his things in a bag by the bed, where she kept moving them to get through. He put socks in it, a charger, a receipt he meant to keep. One week the receipt was the only thing left and she asked whether he still needed the drawer.

"Yes."

"It's the receipt from that shop." [59]

He had misunderstood her words. [25] She held the drawer while he freed the corner of the paper. It came out with a little split through the amount. He folded it along the split and put it in his pocket.

Later he brought the charger back.

—

In Alder Road she worked until seven on Thursday. Through the closed door of the workroom she could hear Leila rinsing a cup. Eva had expected her to go home at the end of the afternoon, but Leila asked whether she could stay until the rain stopped.

They ate the baked potatoes Eva had bought for herself and Tom. One was still hard in the middle. Leila put it back in the microwave, sat down, then had to get up again because neither of them had pressed the button.

Tom had rung to say he could not face the drive after his shift. Eva had said they could leave it until Saturday. It left her with a welcome breathing space. [245] Later, when he rang again, she did not pick up quickly enough and reached his voicemail on the return call.

Leila asked whether she was upset.

"Only a very little." [54]

"About him?"

"Not only."

She told Leila about the client, and about being paid late for the job before this one, which she had not told Tom because he had already been trying to work out how much he could send Sami that month. Leila listened with her eyes closed. Eva stopped once, thinking she had fallen asleep, and Leila opened one eye.

"I like to hear you talk." [9]

They stayed in the sitting room until the rain eased. There was no view of Sun Court from either window. The photograph Ruth sent of the cold frame showed the closed gate beside it, a corner of the new path and somebody's shoes. Eva enlarged it to see what had come up in the pots. She did not recognise the shoes.

Before Leila left they looked at a leaflet Kit had given Eva about an evening at the print shop. There would be a table where people could bring work and no requirement to talk about it. Leila asked about the chairs. Eva said she would ask. [7]

She put the leaflet in the workroom and closed the door. The other flat key was still on the hook in the kitchen. Tom had used it twice. She put a larger ring on it because he had said he could not find it in his coat.

Ruth's bag of pots was no longer beside the entrance. In the space where it had been, Eva had put a narrow shelf for the post. On it lay a letter forwarded from Sun Court. She opened the envelope, dealt with the bill and put the envelope itself in the drawer. Her former address was visible through the window.

—

On Tuesday the Alder Road agent rang while Eva was trying to get into the hotel and asked whether she was still interested. Eva said yes, louder than she intended, because she had the hotel on

the other line and somebody inside was asking which door she meant.

She booked Friday at eleven.

Leila's move had taken place the previous Wednesday. Graham brought the chair, the curtain and a small table she had not asked for. He said, "It will do for now." [122] She kept it. The mug with the soup in it stood there on Thursday night, although Eva was at the Meridian eating a sandwich beside an unfinished catalogue.

On Friday Leila slept through a telephone appointment. When she rang back she asked for another one, then put the phone down and returned to bed. In the hotel she would have needed to explain when the room could be cleaned. Here she could leave the door shut. The heating came on when she had set it to come on.

She sent Eva a photograph of the chair. There was no red towel opposite. The folded curtain had slipped and the tear was visible beneath the arm.

Leila was settled in Halden. Naomi answered the people who asked about other flats individually. In the group, somebody put *sorted* beside Leila's name. Leila saw it while looking for the grocery number. The driver had found the building but not the door.

Eva put *Halden* beside Leila's name in the new version of *Current Arrangements*. Leila had agreed to the town and her telephone number, not the full address. In the transport section Eva added the taxi company that had brought them back from the viewing. She had almost made a separate heading for visiting afternoons, then left the number where it was.

Eva was returning following repairs. Her Friday viewing was open in the calendar beside the visit order. At Sun Court she had told Ruth she was coming back. She remembered the kitchen, the cup upside down on the cloth, the ease of the turn on the second attempt. She had meant it. [279]

She sent Naomi a message asking for a private conversation after Friday. Then she returned to the access drawing. Clare had confirmed the levels. The drainage work had been authorised, and the owners whose agreement was needed had accepted the line of the path. The price for the new gate was still outstanding.

—

By Thursday there were four fewer paid restaurant hours on Nessa's rota. Two parties had cancelled meals as well as rooms. The restaurant manager would review the hours if bookings improved. Pat had begun asking new guests about dinner when they booked. For now the kitchen was closing earlier on two nights. Nessa told the residents where they could leave washing-up, then asked them not to leave it there overnight.

The correction was still at the top of the hotel's page. The post someone sent Nessa that morning used a tighter crop of the photograph. The words above it were unchanged.

Ruth chose the smaller breakfast, with mushrooms instead of the sausage. Nessa read the order back. Ruth said, "That's what I'm having." [55]

The new rear-door reader had arrived. It was in a cardboard box in the office, awaiting the installer. Nessa's niece put the bell receiver in her pocket before Tom left.

"You can leave that to me," [76] she told him when he reached for it.

He went back upstairs for his coat.

Eva was waiting outside. Pat had changed the shift. The catalogue was finished. They went to a place beyond the station where Tom had booked a table after checking the entrance. Eva had checked the bathroom herself by telephone. Neither had told the other until that afternoon.

At the table he showed her the invitation to interview, which had arrived an hour earlier. She congratulated him. He smiled and straightened his shoulders. [63]

She told him she was viewing a flat in Halden the next morning.

“Leila’s?”

“No. Another one.”

He looked at her for a moment, then at the table. She had wanted to tell him before the food arrived. She waited for him to speak. [338]

“To live in?” he asked.

“Yes. Possibly.”

“I thought the path was going ahead.”

“It is.”

He nodded. Did he understand? She was not sure. [94] When the food came he moved her glass away from the edge, then caught himself and asked whether that was all right.

“It was going to fall,” she said.

“I know.”

They began to eat. After a while he told her that the replacement phone was working and Sami had sent a voice message to Tom’s daughter about her boots. She asked what he had said. Tom played the first few seconds, in which his daughter could be heard laughing over the message, then stopped because it was difficult to hear in the room.

They ate more slowly after that. Eva asked about the interview. Tom asked what the flat was like, and she showed him the plan. He turned it the wrong way first. She put her finger beside the small room and explained where the worktable would go.

Her phone rang before he had finished looking. Graham wanted to know whether she was near the drawings. The gate supplier could use the hinges he had bought, but the latch shown on the estimate was not the one she had tried. He was with the man now.

Eva opened the attachment. Tom held the printed menu upright beside her phone to cut the glare from the window.

“Not that one,” she said. “There was a longer handle.”

Graham passed the phone across. The man began describing something she could not see. Eva asked him to send a photograph with his hand beside it, then turned back through the drawings to find the height of the fixing. Tom’s food was cooling. He kept the menu where it was while she looked.

5. Available Space

“It’s more like a landing than a room,” she said. [325]

The agent stayed in the sitting-room doorway while Eva came through, then moved into the kitchen, where she prevented the cupboard opening. They changed places twice before finding positions from which both could look at the same thing.

“I can wait outside,” [317] the agent said.

“Not yet. Could you hold this?”

Eva gave her the end of the tape. The workroom door opened against the wall she had chosen for shelves. There was room on the opposite wall, but then the screen would face the window. She asked about a blind. The agent said the fittings were already there.

The small room was not beautiful. Its ceiling had been painted around an old light fitting rather than after removing it. A street tree interrupted the light. A very private study. [96] She did not move. [326]

The agent, whose name was Beth, had been told to expect someone interested in making alterations. She had photographs of a previous tenant’s kitchen, which established that a cupboard could be removed without taking out the surface above it. The bathroom cabinet was freestanding. They moved it into the hall and Eva tried the turn again.

Better.

She asked Beth to put it back before they left. She had not yet decided. [147]

In the courtyard they met the woman from upstairs carrying two bags. She put them down to find her keys. One contained bottles that struck each other gently when she moved it.

“Viewing?”

“Yes.”

“It’s quiet. Apart from me.”

She laughed and waited for Beth to laugh. Eva asked about deliveries. The woman pointed to the sheltered space beside the stairs. People used it, although things were not supposed to be left there. She had a package inside for the flat opposite and could not get anyone to answer the door.

“You’d think I wanted it,” she said.

When she had gone, Beth explained the application. The owner would consider the proposed alterations, but needed an estimate and an account of what would be put back at the end. Eva needed references and evidence of income. Beth would send the list. There was another viewing that afternoon.

“How long is the tenancy?”

They went through the terms. Eva asked Beth to email rather than telephone. Beth said, “I’ll send you a line.” [321]

On the way to the taxi Eva stopped at the print shop.

The man behind the counter was changing a roll in a machine which had made a large paper cone around his feet. Eva waited beside the envelopes.

She asked whether he could make a proof from her file. He said yes, after lunch. She would have gone by then.

“Tomorrow?”

“I don’t live here.” [256]

“Email it. I’ll keep it.”

He wrote the address on a card. His name was Owen. The machine began to feed paper correctly and he stopped it again to inspect the edge.

“What’s it for?” he asked.

She showed him the catalogue on her phone. He enlarged a page of steel handles until all the lettering disappeared.

“That reflection wants taking out.”

“No,” Eva said.

“It’s somebody’s sleeve.”

“I know.”

He looked more closely. [199] A line of blue. [197]

“Still,” he said.

She laughed and took the phone back. Beside the envelopes was a card printed with a dense orange square. Under the shop light it had almost no visible grain. She turned it over in her hand. [79]

The paper was thick, substantial. [190]

—

At the Meridian, somebody had put a chair in front of the new reader.

It was waiting to be collected from the dining room. Eva moved it far enough to reach the card slot, used her card, and came through before the release ended. The alteration worked. She came back out and tried it from the other side, then moved the chair again so the next person would not have to.

Pat asked whether the longer delay was sufficient.

“Yes.”

“Good.”

Pat made a tick on the delivery note and went to find Nessa. They stood by the door while Olha tried the card from inside, holding a bag against her hip.

“Better?” Pat asked.

Olha nodded. Her phone rang as she came through. She set the bag down [57] and answered, then held up a finger when Nessa asked about Saturday.

“My mother,” she said afterwards. “She says don’t book it yet. Yesterday she said book it.”

“Can she stay where she is?”

“For now. They’re still working on the flat.”

Nessa took the rota out of her pocket. Olha looked from the phone to the Saturday column and asked about the later shift.

Eva sent the photographs and measurements from Alder Road to the person who had done her kitchen years before. He was not available to do the work. He could look at the photographs on Sunday and tell her whether the estimate she eventually obtained sounded reasonable. She thanked him.

Tom had sent a message asking how the viewing went.

She wrote that it was good. There was work to be done. [53]

It was good. I’m working out the costs.

He answered when he finished getting ready for his interview. He wanted to know whether she would be in the dining room later.

At four he arrived wearing a shirt she had not seen. He pulled at his collar. [142] He asked her to look at a page of possible questions.

“They might not ask these,” she said.

“I know. Ask anyway.”

He had used the job description and his application to make them. Some were useful. One asked him to describe a time he had influenced a multidisciplinary team. They spent several minutes deciding whether the plumber, Pat and an angry woman in room four constituted a team. Then Eva asked the question without the wording, and he answered it.

She noticed that he kept saying *they* when he meant the hotel.

“I haven’t left,” he said when she mentioned it.

“No.”

He took back the page and wrote something in the margin. Before going on duty he kissed her beside the service door. Nessa

came through carrying a bowl, saw them and backed through again. A spoon struck the door frame. He began to laugh; [168] she drew him to her. [199]

—

The emergency-planning officer arrived on Monday, in the fifth week after the fire, with a large plan of the district and a much smaller one of the hotel.

The visit had been arranged as part of a regional exercise about interrupted power and transport. It was not a warning that something was about to happen. The first thing Pat asked was whether she could put that sentence on the notice. Since the photograph appeared, a man had twice rung to ask whether the hotel was being used by the government for a purpose she was refusing to reveal.

“Please do,” the officer said.

He spread the hotel plan over two tables. Naomi had brought the accommodation list. Tom knew the building. Eva was there because the officer wanted to check the arrangements for the rear studio, and because the smaller plan did not show the door she used.

At six the rear reader stopped accepting cards. Eva was in the studio. The duty manager came down the passage, checked that she had her bag and went ahead to open the second route. A guest in the dining room stood with his coat on, holding the back of the chair he had been asked to move. He wanted to know whether he should take it with him.

“Just leave it clear.”

The table was already against the wall. Beyond it the corridor turned left. The manager waited at the heavy door while Eva came round. Then the door closed behind them. In the bar somebody had found the battery lamp used when the fuse went the previous

winter. It lit the bottom of the till and the glass bowl containing the receipts. Pat put it on a higher shelf.

By twenty past six all the hotel's residents were accounted for. The family from the front bedroom were together on a bench. Eva had a place where she could wait without people having to pass immediately behind her. She asked whether the lamp could be turned a little away from her face. Tom moved it.

"Who's on at six?" Nessa asked.

Tom looked towards the office.

The officer asked Eva where she would go if the rear route were unavailable.

"Unavailable how?"

He looked at the plan. Eva waited. If he meant a fire, the answer would not be the same as for a failed reader. If he meant a vehicle parked across the yard, she wanted the vehicle moved rather than a new description of herself.

They walked the routes. The front of the pub had a step. There was a second way through the dining room when the appropriate doors were unlocked, though reaching it required moving a table and ensuring that the passage beyond was not used for deliveries. Nessa moved the table. Eva asked to try before they wrote anything down.

The passage was usable. The final door was heavy enough that she could not comfortably hold it while turning. The officer asked what normally happened.

"We use the other one," Eva said.

Tom held the door. The officer made a note.

"Who covers when you're not here?"

"Whoever's on duty."

The officer asked for the duty arrangements rather than a name. Tom began explaining the overlap between the bar, rooms and restaurant, then went to fetch the actual rota. Pat brought the key

for the second door. It was on a different ring from the key the early staff carried.

They returned to the tables. Pat ordered another key cut and asked for a hook in the office. Nessa wanted a second person named on the early shift, not the name of someone who normally came in later. They marked the overlap on the rota. The officer crossed out the sentence saying the route had been confirmed and wrote what remained to be tried.

She was glad of that. [139] Her hands were cold. [40] Nessa put a cup near her hand and asked if the inspection had finished with the table.

“Two minutes,” the officer said.

Tom had been entered as the contact for the rear studio on a sheet assembled before the visit. He was usually there late, he knew the route and he had answered the previous questions. The officer changed the entry to *duty manager* and wrote the desk number. In the emergency contact column beside Eva’s name was Ruth’s mobile.

“I need to ask her about that,” Eva said.

“Of course.”

“I put it there.”

The officer did not look surprised. He gave her a separate form.

When Ruth came in, she agreed to remain the emergency contact. She wanted Eva’s number on her own form. Then she asked which kinds of emergency they meant. Naomi stayed while they went through it.

The district plan was rolled up and taken away. On the hotel copy someone had drawn the rear door in pencil. Pat deleted Tom’s name from the walkthrough and put it beside the booking instructions. That Tuesday Laura followed the line round the table. At six the duty manager reached the studio. By twenty past six everyone was accounted for. Below that, in a different type size, were the keys still to be cut and the cover still to be agreed.

—

Leila had meant to open the letter when it arrived. It was beside the green chair, beneath a catalogue she had never requested and above a menu delivered through the communal entrance.

On Tuesday she moved the catalogue and discovered she had already opened it.

The housing team wanted an account of how the move had worked. She could speak to someone or complete the questions in writing. There was an invitation to allow a short description to be used in a review. She could decline that part without declining the rest.

She wanted to help. [153] It cost her an effort. [189]

She answered the heating question immediately. The bedroom was separate from the sitting room; she no longer had to choose between somewhere to rest and somewhere to put things. The rubbish arrangement had begun, after two missed collections and a telephone call in which she had given the number of the wrong entrance. Grocery deliveries were still awkward. The communal bell did not tell her which door the driver had reached.

She dictated these things into her phone, stopping while someone in the next flat ran water. When she read them, they looked as if she were listing faults. She added that moving had made a substantial difference. She moved it to the beginning.

The drafting system gave her an account with headings. It put the separate rooms before the remaining difficulties. Leila had begun with the rubbish because that was the thing she had spent the morning trying to resolve. She moved through the new order twice. She wanted the first part read even by someone who did not reach the second.

For the review, she allowed two sentences about the separate rooms and the heating. She did not allow her photograph. She left her name off the public version and put it on the reply to Helen.

The move had worked. Leila could rest without clearing away the rest of the day. Eva read those sentences in the message Leila sent her and began an answer about Thursday. She deleted it before sending. Thursday had not been offered.

After sending the account, Leila spent the rest of the afternoon in bed. She had no energy left. [327] The unanswered message from Eva was only asking how she was; she had no useful short answer.

At seven she wrote, *Better here. Tired. Not up to talking.*

Eva sent a photograph of a page in which two handles had finally been given the same product number. Leila enlarged it and wrote, *They've found each other.*

She put the phone down beside the unwashed mug.

—

The invitation arrived at the hotel addressed to the Sun Court residents, care of Eva Shaw.

It came from the agent acting for Dacre, who owned three cottages, including the one Leila had rented. He wanted to discuss the longer-term future of the court while repairs were in progress. Owners could explore a sale without committing to one. Tenants would be offered an individual discussion. The document described a mixed arrangement of permanent homes and short stays, improved shared areas and a new service store. On the last page was a drawing in which the court looked wider because none of the bins had been included.

Eva read the enclosure twice. She recognised the outline of the access route from Clare's drawing. It was now a pale strip connecting her house to a shared area labelled GARDEN.

The route no longer crossed Ruth's garden.

The covering note referred to the successful permanent relocation of one household. She could picture the bedroom. [184] Dacre's agent had not seen the flat. In his copy of the residents' sheet, the entry was *Halden — permanent*.

Denise came over before Eva had decided how to circulate the invitation. Her husband wanted the offer valued. They had repair contributions to find and had been thinking about leaving before the fire. She seemed to expect Eva to object.

“I’m not saying sell it to him,” she said. “I want to know what he’d pay.”

“Then ask.”

“You’ll come?”

“I haven’t decided.”

“It’s about the access as well.”

Eva looked at the drawing again. The invitation named her as the residents’ contact because she was the person whose name appeared at the top of the shared document. Her telephone number was correct.

She sent it to the group with a note that she had not arranged the meeting and was not representing anyone’s decision. Then she called Naomi, who said she had not arranged it either. She would attend to distinguish the accommodation work from the proposal, not to recommend a sale.

Ruth read the pages at the dining-room table. She asked whether the shared garden was supposed to include her warm wall. Eva said no. The boundary was there, although it was difficult to see beneath a tree that did not exist.

“And this is my gate?”

“The old one.”

“It looks blocked.”

“It’s drawn shut.”

Ruth turned the page. She disliked the proposal, but she liked that part of the picture. When Eva offered to enlarge it, Ruth said she could see well enough.

Her phone sounded beneath the proposal. She put the papers aside. [208] The surgery could see her on Tuesday morning. She

wrote that down. [64] Beneath the time she added the trouble after meals to the note about her back.

That night Beth emailed from Alder Road. The owner would consider the alterations described in Eva's note. Beth needed an application by Thursday if Eva wished to be considered before the other interested person.

Eva opened the account of the workroom. She knew what she wanted. [84] She stayed on that page until a message came asking whether she could bring printed copies of Dacre's proposal to the meeting.

She had enough paper. The printer was in the office, and Tom was on duty.

6. The Preferred Plan

The new store stood against the blank wall. The bins were inside it, and the narrow passage no longer had to accommodate bicycles as well. Anwar’s daughter opened the lower bolt herself. There was a place for her bicycle beside another child’s, whose owner arrived on Fridays and left again on Sundays. At first they argued about which space was which. Then one bicycle was changed for a larger one and they began parking the other way round.

Ruth learned the number for repairs. A woman answered who did not need to be told where the cottages were. When the outside light failed, Ruth reported it on Monday and someone came on Wednesday, while she was at the Meridian. She had not had to remain at home to say which light. When she returned it was working, although it was brighter than the one it replaced.

On Friday evening a couple passed her gate with a case on wheels. They had been told where to leave it while they fetched the key. They stopped to admire the plants. Ruth named one of them and forgot the other. “You will come again, I hope.” [323]

Eva came through the new entrance with bread. Her house was still hers. The people in the short-stay cottages could look into the shared garden but not into Ruth’s. A timber screen took care of that. Eva had objected to its height until Ruth made her sit where she could see the neighbouring window. Then she agreed.

The bread went on the table. There was room to move around. [187] At four the woman who answered the maintenance number went home. The light came on above the passage before anyone noticed it was getting dark.

—

Denise had brought a calculator, although the agent said there were no individual prices to discuss that afternoon.

“Then what are we discussing?” she asked.

“Whether there’s enough interest to commission them.”

He produced the impression of keeping copies of everything he said. [11] He moved a stack of pages away from the coffee cups. Dacre was not there. He had sent apologies and an outline of what he was willing to consider.

The wider view of the shared garden was on the front page. [89]

They sat at three tables in the dining room. Two had been pushed together; Naomi occupied the end of the third because she needed to leave before lunch. Anwar had asked his sister to collect his daughter. Ruth had missed a game of pool. He was courteous, even politely cordial; [108] and she did not like him. [72]

He explained the proposal. Dacre could buy cottages from owners wishing to sell. He could take responsibility for work to the shared areas under an arrangement to be agreed with the remaining owners. He might convert some vacant properties to short-stay use. The repairs already authorised were separate from this discussion.

“Would he buy mine?” Denise asked.

“He’d consider it.”

“How much below what it was worth before the fire?”

“I can’t give you a figure today.”

“Can you give me a figure for what it was worth before?”

He made a note. [157]

Anwar wanted to know what vacant meant. His house was empty because he was not allowed into it. He still paid what he had been told to pay and had not agreed to go anywhere else.

“The proposal isn’t treating occupied tenancies as vacant properties,” the agent said.

“It’s a drawing of my house with a different door.”

“The drawing is illustrative.”

Anwar turned it towards him. The new door led to a deck. It would have occupied the patch where his daughter left her bicycle because it was sheltered from the rain. The agent took out a pen [287] and wrote *existing tenancy* beside the house.

Naomi asked for a clean version of that distinction to be sent to everyone. She would not be communicating offers on Dacre’s behalf. The accommodation placements and the proposal were separate matters. When the agent asked whether the housing team could help people explore alternatives, she said people could contact her individually. She could not offer the room a collection of homes they had not seen.

“One household has found that the move worked very well,” he said.

“Leila found a particular flat,” Eva said.

“Of course. I’m not suggesting—”

Denise interrupted. She wanted to know whether there was any way to obtain a valuation without joining a programme. Yes, the agent said. He repeated his phrases. [176]

Ruth watched Eva straighten the printed copies. They had used the hotel printer after dinner and found that one cartridge was nearly empty. The print was very faint. [318]

She asked about the path.

The path was part of the shared work. The agent said some of the expense might be carried by a purchaser acquiring more than one interest in the court. They would need to understand who was responsible for what. It was not necessary for Eva to sell in order to discuss it.

“Or for me to stay?” Eva asked.

He sipped his coffee. [343]

“The route remains a property matter,” he said. “It doesn’t disappear if ownership changes.”

Several people were looking at Eva when Denise was still waiting for a price.

Naomi had to leave. She stayed long enough to give Anwar a number for independent housing advice, then put the proposal back in its envelope. The agent asked whether Eva would collect residents' responses. She said no. He wrote his own contact details on the first page of each copy. Someone asked whether the printed deadline was compulsory. It was a date for establishing interest, he said. A separate half-sheet gave the dates and times. [340]

The repair number had no digits yet. Under the weekend was the agent's instruction to the writer: *ordinary use, not a holiday advertisement*. Ruth turned back to the page on which the woman answered it.

Afterwards Nessa needed the tables. The agent helped separate them. Denise remained beside him while he stacked his papers, asking about the valuation. Ruth went to the bar without waiting for Eva.

Anwar stayed behind with the copy on which his house had been marked as an existing tenancy. The agent had promised a clean drawing. Anwar wanted something from the residents as well.

"Not just that we've been spoken to."

Eva put the cups together. She needed to send Beth the alteration estimate. On the page under Anwar's hand, his daughter had drawn a bicycle beside the new store.

"What do you want it to say?"

"That we want our homes back."

She opened the shared notes. The first answer the drafting window offered thanked the agent for a constructive discussion and said the residents welcomed the opportunity to consider their options. Eva read it aloud. Anwar shook his head before she finished.

"Not that."

She asked for the refusal to be clear without refusing the valuations people had requested. The next version began with the repairs and ended with individual decisions. In the middle was the sentence Anwar had wanted.

We want our homes back.

She copied it to the beginning. It looked stronger there. She asked him to read [247] the rest.

He changed a word about his tenancy and added his name. Denise wanted the sentence about valuations kept, so Eva moved it higher. Ruth read the message on her phone and answered *Yes, send that.* There were five names by the time Eva sent it. Leila's was not one of them.

The residents were coming back. They had rejected the suggestion that an emptied court was a court available for somebody else's plan. The agent acknowledged the message and sent Anwar a drawing with his existing door restored. Denise received a date for the valuation. Eva went back to [166] correcting a galley of proof. [113]

Beth's deadline was Thursday.

—

The small room was empty again by the following Thursday.

Beth had sent the other applicant's forms to the owner. Eva opened her own message from Tuesday: *I can't proceed yet.* Beth's answer was immediately below it, with an offer to keep looking.

She had done the sums. She owned her cottage at Sun Court, but owning it was not the same as having the proceeds of a sale in hand. She had savings and invoices outstanding. There would be rent, alterations and a period of paying for two properties before a sale. She needed more time. [307]

That afternoon, the invoice she had been waiting for was paid.

It had come too late. [134] She moved part of it into the account from which she paid tax, then looked at the Alder Road particulars.

It was only a picture. [135] In the live advertisement a narrow band said LET AGREED. She could still enlarge the kitchen. The photographs had not been taken away.

She could almost see [111] the shop she wanted. [323] Eva enlarged the photograph of the street and tried to find the shop. The red awning belonged to a business that sold phone cases.

She turned away from the screen. [145] The window was wide open. [204]

Ruth came to the studio with the keys collected during the latest visit. One was Eva's; the other opened a replacement padlock which neither woman would need after the services were restored.

"How did it go?" she asked.

"What?"

"The place you were looking at."

Eva had told Ruth after the meeting. She could not think of any reply. [308]

"It's gone."

"Oh."

"Somebody else took it."

Ruth put the keys on the table. She felt somewhat relieved. [43] Then she looked away. [211]

"It wasn't the only one," she said.

"No."

"Are you going to keep looking?"

"I don't know."

"I'd like to know before I hear it at a meeting."

"I'd like to know before then too."

Ruth sat down. The cold frame was now in a borrowed shed, after a second journey and a payment to the man who carried it. Having to feel grateful— [12] it was a nuisance. [148]

“You said you were coming back.”

“I know.”

“I believed you.”

“So did I.”

But she regretted her words already. [292] Ruth was looking at the keys.

Ruth took her coat off. It was too warm in the studio. “I want to ask you a favour.” [128]

“If you sell, I don’t want somebody being shown the route through my garden.”

“Neither do I.”

“They’ll see a gate.”

“We can put something in the particulars.”

“Not just in the particulars.”

Eva nodded. She drew the new route on the back of the particulars, making the line dark enough to show through the page.

Ruth looked at it. [136]

“Anwar’s going to use what you wrote.”

“For the adviser?”

“He said it was what he’d been trying to say.”

Eva asked whether he had the version with the names on it. Ruth said yes. Eva put down the pen and said he should use it.

They discussed paint. Ruth preferred a dark green Eva found too close to black. Eva wanted something that showed the latch clearly. Ruth fetched the colour card from her bag and left it on the table.

“Keep it,” she said. “I’ve got another.”

Behind the colour card was the referral for a scan. Ruth turned it over in her hand. [79] The doctor had examined her and arranged blood tests. She had lost weight. She had not noticed it before. [186]

“Can I help you?” [188] Eva asked.

“My sister’s coming. I’ll tell you when I know anything.”

Ruth shifted her weight. The pain did not grow less. [331] She had told the doctor it began at the hotel. She was in the kitchen, [321] standing at her own sink when it first happened. She remembered now that it had been before the fire. She wrote that down. [64]

“It kept stopping,” Ruth said.

—

Leila heard about the meeting from Graham, who had come to tighten a leg on the small table.

He described the proposal while he worked. There was a hole in his sock. [169] He had asked for a cup of tea and then let it cool because the screw would not engage.

“They ought to give everyone the option you had.”

“It isn’t the same option.”

“You know what I mean. At least you needed it. Some of them —”

“Could you bring the table back now?”

“It’ll only wobble.”

“I need my water.”

He put the table beside her and fetched the glass. She thanked him. He returned to the subject, distinguishing people who worked from people who had never tried. She said she was not having that conversation. He gathered up his things [86] with an injured air. [211]

At the door he asked whether she needed anything else from the cottage. She said there was a lamp, but it could wait until she had sent a photograph. He said he would look out for the message.

After he left, she drank the water. The table still moved a little. She found the photograph of the lamp and sent it to him before putting the phone on charge.

Eva sent the paragraph from the proposal when Leila asked for it. The successful relocation occupied less than two lines. The rest concerned the financial and practical advantages of considering a different arrangement for the court.

Leila began a reply to the residents. She spoke into her phone. [99]

The draft put the improvement first and her refusal of the proposal second. Leila kept that order. In the longer version, it said she was grateful to have escaped her former circumstances. She removed *escaped*. The heating, the bedroom and the bus stop remained.

She kept three sentences. The flat was better for her. She had chosen it after seeing it twice and asking about the things that mattered to her. She was not recommending Dacre's proposal and had not been asked to take part in it.

She added a request not to ring about the message. Written replies were fine, but she might not answer immediately. She signed it *Leila* rather than *L.*, which she usually used when she was tired.

Denise replied that nobody was trying to make her an example. Then she asked privately whether Helen had other places. Leila forwarded the contact number, with permission, and left the rest until morning.

Anwar sent both messages to the adviser: Leila's and the one beginning *We want our homes back*. Denise arranged her valuation. Their circumstances were different. [68] The adviser asked when Eva could speak.

—

On the first wet evening, the new path did not flood.

Eva watched from the kitchen while the water found the channel beside the fence. The old dip had held it for days. Now leaves gathered against a grate which somebody would need to

clear. She took a photograph and sent it to Clare, who answered the next morning with a thumbs-up and a reminder about the leaves.

Tom was late. Eva had started eating when he arrived. He had a key but knocked because he could see the light and knew she disliked being surprised while working.

"Come in."

He stood dripping on the mat and said his daughter had rung from a bus she had taken in the wrong direction. There was nothing he could do from Merewick except wait while she found the stop to get off. "She sounded all right to me." [219]

Eva handed him a towel. [140] He ate the remaining food from the saucepan. It had gone soft at the edges, but there was enough.

Ruth rang to ask whether they could hear the water running along the new drain. Eva said yes. Ruth said it was louder than she expected. She did not ask them to come and listen. His clothes were not drying well. [330] They sat in the kitchen. [105]

In the morning Eva found a message from Leila about a film. They arranged Sunday, provided the transport worked. And the long, long Sundays spaced the weeks and the months. [274]

—

The drainage estimate arrived with a photograph of the opened ground.

The pipe was worse than Graham thought. The budget for the fire-damaged services would cover one part, but not all the paving disturbed by changing the route. The owners had a shared maintenance fund, which had never been large enough for all the things they had postponed. They could use some of it. The new gate was a separate cost. Naomi had found a limited contribution towards the access work; she wanted the quote checked before anyone ordered anything.

Eva asked whether they needed an answer about where she would live.

“They need an accurate account of the work,” Naomi said. “And I need you to tell me when your accommodation plan changes. Those aren’t the same form.”

“I may not go back.”

Naomi asked whether she wanted help finding another placement. Eva explained about Alder Road and the small room. She described where the table would have gone before remembering that Naomi had never asked.

“There may be something else,” Naomi said. “I can ask. I can’t offer you that one.”

Eva knew.

They went through the estimate. Dacre agreed to his share of the communal repairs without anyone accepting the wider proposal. Two owners wanted staged payments. One objected to the new surface until Clare explained which part of the cost would arise even if they rebuilt the old route. It took four days. [46]

The order went in during the seventh week. The gate would use Graham’s hinges. The longer handle was specified on the final drawing, with the fixing height checked against the photograph Eva had requested over dinner. A line in the work schedule said *resident returning*. Clare changed it to *resident access* after Eva asked. The order itself did not change.

The copy attached to the payment request still said resident returning. Clare had changed the schedule. The payment form had already been made from it.

Eva asked whether the light would fall across the new threshold. Clare drew its angle on the plan. It would miss the latch unless the fitting was moved. There was a small extra cost, and Eva agreed to pay it.

In the account of the wet evening, Tom had stood under that light while she found him the towel. She had not noticed it before. [186]

Tom’s offer arrived that afternoon. The maintenance contractor wanted him for induction and supervised work in the smaller buildings. He called his daughter. [289]

Pat congratulated him, then asked him to look at the notice period with her. Laura could cover two evenings, not the rest. But there was no need to apologise. [204] She asked to look at his books. [323]

He took them out of the drawer. There were notes inside in three kinds of ink. The booking system instructions he had used to train Laura were on his own laptop. He copied them to the office computer, checked they opened, and noticed he had put his mobile number at the bottom of every page.

He changed the number. Then he went to tell Nessa, who asked whether finishing at four meant he would finally eat before ten. He said that was the plan.

7. The Long Handle

Graham held the handle against a piece of timber while Eva tried it.

“Higher?”

“Leave it there.”

He had marked three possible positions in pencil. The one on the drawing was the middle one. It was right when she approached from the court, less comfortable when she came out with something on her lap. She asked to try the lower mark. Then she asked him to put it back.

He rubbed out the line. [228]

He used to order small quantities from a supplier in Belgium. After Brexit the firm had stopped handling his small British orders, and he had spent an afternoon pricing a batch large enough to be worth shipping. He could not afford to keep that much stock. Now he bought through the wholesaler or asked other tradesmen what they had left. The hinges had come from a cancelled job of a friend’s.

The gate itself was leaning against the fence, [150] newly painted. Ruth had chosen the green; Eva had chosen a lighter plate behind the latch. The longer handle lay in its opened packet at Graham’s feet.

Clare came to look at the final levels. The drain had been repaired, the broken surface lifted and replaced. Along the edge, small areas of old concrete remained visible beside the new work.

Eva waited until the tools were clear before making the turn. The path took her behind the cottages, past the blank wall where the store had been, and to an opening she could approach without going through Ruth's garden. She came back the other way. The wheel did not drop into the old depression. She had expected that movement and had tightened her hands before reaching it.

"Does it feel all right?" [316]

"Yes."

"Not too rough?"

"It's all right."

He stooped to pick up [51] the packet. Eva turned again, without being asked, and went as far as her door. The electricity was on for testing. Through the window she could hear the refrigerator running.

Clare wanted to check the drainage after rain before signing off that part. Eva asked for the maintenance instructions to be sent to her as well as to the owners. Clare entered another address on her phone.

Ruth was waiting inside with the kettle. She had been given permission to use the house while they attended the inspection, but not to sleep there yet. A contractor was still testing the shared circuits. He had asked them not to switch on the heater at the same time as his equipment.

"Tea?"

"Yes, I'll have some tea." [137]

She put down her cup. [188]

Ruth had opened the window. [102] The room smelled of the house, mixed with new sealant from work beyond it. On the counter were the onions, which should have been thrown away weeks ago. Ruth asked whether she could take the basket outside to empty it.

"Please."

She returned with the basket rinsed. Eva had begun opening drawers. The smaller stapler was at the hotel. The larger one had remained beneath papers in the workroom and still worked when she pressed it against the edge of a folded leaflet. She pulled out the staples with her nail and put them in a dish.

The sound of the sea was a vague murmur. [203]

"Something has eaten almost all of my tender young lettuce." [97]

"It may just be enjoying itself," Eva said.

"It can enjoy something cheaper."

The contractor called through that he needed to turn the power off again. Ruth filled a second cup before he did. Eva stayed at the counter, not working on anything.

Ruth checked the scan appointment. She read that first line again. [252] It was the following afternoon. Beneath the time were the instructions about eating. She examined it carefully. [117]

"Will you ring me afterwards?" Eva asked.

"I'll send you a line." [321]

"Call me if you need anything." [131]

Eva left her cup beside the sink. She picked up her coat. [275]

—

On the way back, she asked the driver to take the coast road.

It was longer, though not by enough to alter the fare they had agreed. The fisherman's hut was small, [95] with a roof that looked heavy on its low walls. [174] Further on, a stretch of shingle had been fenced to keep people away from nesting birds, with a narrow gap left for the signed path.

Eva had once designed a leaflet for a group trying to protect that stretch. Pictures didn't make much show. [62] The group had paid late, apologised and asked her to do another one the following year. She had said yes.

Near the nuclear site, the driver slowed for a vehicle carrying equipment too wide for the road. People still worked in the buildings, although from a distance decommissioning could look remarkably like nothing happening. Tom would be working in one of the smaller blocks to begin with. He had shown Eva a map of where to report, then put it away before either of them started discussing how near it was to her house.

The driver asked whether the repairs were finished.

"Nearly."

"Back next week, then?"

"Some of us."

He nodded. When they reached the hotel, he asked her to send the new address whenever it was settled. She said she would.

Beth had left a message. There was another flat in Halden, in Mercer Street, which had not appeared in Eva's search because it had only one bedroom. The kitchen had an opening beneath the sink. Beth remembered the turning space from their viewing. It might be worth looking at.

Eva rang her back before putting the kettle on.

—

Mercer Street was further from the print shop and nearer Leila.

The front entrance had a step. The rear route was step-free, through a courtyard divided between three flats, with no private garden to cross. There were two doors and a slight incline which Eva wanted to try with something on her lap. Beth lent her the folder.

Inside, the sitting room had an alcove that could take part of the worktable, not all of it. The screen would need to be moved before she could eat with another person. The bedroom had room beside the bed on the side she preferred. In the bathroom she could turn without removing anything. She stayed there while Beth measured the passage again.

The previous tenant had removed two kitchen cupboard doors and put them in the store. The owner wanted to know whether Eva wanted them back on. She said no. There was a plug socket at the wrong end of the useful surface. Moving it would be a small job if permission and someone to do it could be found. She wrote that down. [64]

"A work-room should be like an old shoe." [62]

A man in the next courtyard began practising a trumpet. He played the same few bars, stopped, and played them more slowly. Beth said she had not heard that on her previous visit.

She could not help laughing. [311]

"What?"

"Nothing. I was going to ask about noise."

"We can find out."

They did. The man taught two afternoons a week. He practised himself at other times. Eva asked which wall his room shared with this one and whether there was usually amplification. He came into the courtyard carrying the trumpet and seemed relieved to be asked a question he could answer. He had been worried she was complaining already.

At the second visit, on the following afternoon, one of the pupils was there. The music ceased, apparently in the middle of a bar. [29]

She had brought a bag and a folder of work. She used the rear route, came in, put the bag where she would put it, then asked Beth to leave her alone for a few minutes. She could see to read. [151]

She read that first line again. [252]

—

Leila came to the end of the street to meet her after the viewing. She had wanted to see how far it was. Halfway back she asked to

sit on a low wall. Eva waited beside her and said nothing about how close they were.

After a while Leila pointed to a shop at the corner.

"They keep things behind the counter for me. I have to pay first."

"What things?"

"Mostly things I don't need."

They went in. Eva bought a drink while the woman found Leila's biscuits and magazine. Leila put the magazine back because she had already read that issue. She paid for the biscuits and asked about the next issue. Eva took a sip; [173] she faintly shuddered. "Dreadfully sweet!" [203]

At Leila's flat she managed the bathroom turn by approaching differently. It was awkward, but possible without taking the door off. Leila showed her where she could leave the chair while Eva moved onto the other seat. Eva was irritated that she had not seen it before. Leila wanted to lie down. [35]

"Stay a bit," Leila said. "I'll be back."

The empty green chair. [14]

She answered two messages and checked her taxi booking. There was not another bus at the time she would need one.

Leila came back sooner than Eva expected and sat without speaking for several minutes. Then she asked whether Eva had liked the flat.

"Yes."

"More than the other one?"

"No."

"Enough?"

"I think so."

They shared the biscuits. Leila liked the drink Eva had bought and finished it. She had forgotten to arrange milk for the following morning. Eva offered to get some on the way out, then realised the

taxi was booked from the front entrance and there would not be time. Leila said she would ask the shop. She had done it before.

At the corner Eva could see Mercer Street from where the taxi turned. She sent Beth a message asking for the application.

—

Ruth was in the bar when Eva found her. Len had gone home weeks ago, but she had begun playing with a woman who worked at the station and came over between duties. They were arguing about whether a ball had touched the cushion. Both were enjoying the argument.

She waited in silence. [189]

"You can stay," the woman said. "We're finished."

Ruth put the cue away. She picked up her coat. [275]

They went into another room. [20] There was not much said on either side. [95]

"I'm applying for the other flat."

"The smaller one?"

"Yes."

Ruth sat down.

"To live in."

"Yes."

"And the house?"

"I'll sell it. Not immediately. I need to get everything out and have it valued."

"To him?"

"I haven't agreed anything with Dacre."

She unbuttoned her coat. [60]

"I thought you wanted to see what it was like with the path."

"I have seen."

"For an hour."

"It was good."

"Then why—"

A family passed the window. The voices of the [76] children in the street. [125] “Take the next train home?” [249]

“I want to live somewhere else,” Eva said.

The old granite saucepan. [213]

“Is it because of the gate?”

“No.”

“Not at all?”

No words came to her. [308]

“I don’t know,” she said. “Not because you wanted your garden.”

Ruth took off her coat and laid it over her knees.

“I wanted to have my garden. I also thought we’d still be living next door.”

They stopped; they waited for each other. [203]

They sat without speaking. Ruth looked at the particulars of Mercer Street. The photograph showed the alcove at an angle which made it appear deeper than it was. Eva pointed this out. Ruth asked where the worktable would go.

“Part of it there. The rest on a trolley.”

“You hate working in the sitting room.”

“I hate not having somewhere to put it away.”

“That looks like the same thing.”

“Some of it might be.”

Ruth handed the page back.

“What’s the deposit?”

Eva told her.

“And you start paying before you move in?”

“A few days.”

The torn sleeve lining. [1] “I shall have to mend it.” [189]

At the door Ruth turned.

“I’m not telling everybody for you.”

“I’ll do it.”

“And you’ll still need to collect the box from mine.”

"Yes."

She drew her scarf about her. [175]

—

The application asked for an employer.

Eva put *self-employed* and attached the accounts Beth had requested. There was room for a reference, not for an explanation of the variation between one month and another. She supplied the figures in the form they had asked for, then wrote a separate note about the small works they had discussed.

The next box asked why she was moving. She put in the hotel, the repairs, the two flats and the work she did. There was no room for the first version. She asked for something shorter.

Eva had been considering a move for some time. The fire had brought forward a change she needed to make. Halden would put her nearer a friend and give her a different working arrangement. She would be selling her house once she had moved.

She read it aloud before sending. She let it stand. [118]

She used the drafting window to put the alterations in order. She changed the entry for the socket from *essential* to *desirable* and sent the list with the clear courtyard route first.

She returned to the request for Mercer Street: *Sunday, two weeks after moving*. She had put in the trumpet and the alcove. The first account gave her the separate workroom again. She selected the sentence about its door and replaced it with the width of the sitting room.

There was a worktable, a plain one with an oilcloth cover. [339] A six-inch steel ruler. [335]

Ruth came with a plant wrapped in newspaper. At the sound of the first notes, [323] they listened in silence. [189]

A tin can containing a geranium. [22]

The rule remained beneath the cloth.

The spreadsheet included rent, charges at Sun Court and an allowance for work a survey might reveal. She reduced what she had set aside for the flat and looked for second-hand trolleys.

A client rang about three months of catalogue updates. He wanted a price for a fixed number of hours. Eva asked which jobs those hours were meant to include. They went through a list, disagreed about one part, and arranged to speak again after he had sent the files. She did not put that part of the work into the spreadsheet.

She sent the application. Then she sent a shorter message to the residents, saying she was arranging to live in Halden and would not be returning permanently. She would finish the information she had promised about the access work and make sure people knew who to contact after that. She did not give the address.

Anwar replied that he was glad she had found somewhere. Denise asked whether the sale would affect the collective offer. Ruth did not reply. A resident staying with his son sent a photograph of the newly painted gate and wrote that it was a shame.

She examined it carefully. [117]

—

Tom came to the studio after work, carrying the mug Eva had left in the dining room.

He knocked. She asked him in. For a while they talked about the application and his first day. He had been sent three documents to read before induction and had printed the one which turned out to be available there. Eva showed him the room in Mercer Street. He asked whether there was somewhere to park.

“Round the corner.”

“Can I see the route?”

He studied the map. [48]

He stayed that night. She told him where she wanted the chair and where he could leave his shoes. He listened, then asked about the cup in his way.

"You can move a cup, Tom."

"I'm building up to it."

He put the cup down. [42] Later he kissed the place behind her ear and she turned too quickly, catching his nose with her cheek. He made the injured guest's noise from the story about the moving view. She told him not to do the voice in bed.

She pulled him down to her [325] and held him fast for a minute. [325]

In the morning the refrigerator clicked. "Here, I've brought you a cup of tea." [189]

His phone sounded. He picked it up immediately.

"Work?" she asked.

"Sami."

There was a message about a neighbour who had found another charger and a request to tell Tom's daughter that her reply had arrived. Tom watched the screen. Eva reached for the tea, but he was still holding it.

He sat on the bed and showed her his daughter wearing the boots. Sami had drawn an arrow to one and written something she could not read.

"He says I can stop worrying about her. She's got foundations."

His laughter went off in a loud crack. [204]

He played the voice message again. Eva understood the laughter and his daughter saying that was unfair. She reached over him for the tea.

"One does want one's tea." [324]

—

Beth rang on Wednesday. The owner had accepted the application, subject to the remaining paperwork, and agreed to the

work they had described. Eva asked for the agreement about the courtyard to be included in the email. It would be.

Beth said she hoped it would be worth the long wait, since Eva had been planning the move for some time. Eva recognised the sentence from her application. They were already discussing the keys.

The flat could be ready in the tenth week after the fire. The houses at Sun Court would begin reopening in the ninth.

Naomi laid the dates beside each other. The studio booking could be extended, or Eva could use her house for the six nights before the flat was ready. She chose the house. There were drawers she had not opened since the fire.

“Does that change what I’ve told people?” Naomi asked.

“Only the date I leave the hotel.”

Naomi entered it. Eva checked the number of nights and her telephone number. Behind the form, the gate contractor had sent the final invoice. She forwarded it to the people responsible for the separate payments, then went back to the tenancy agreement Beth had just sent.

8. The First Week Back

The keys were handed back on Tuesday, between breakfast and the arrival of a party who had booked lunch before the fire.

There were always so many things to fix. [62] Naomi had spoken to each household rather than issuing a single date. Several people still asked when everyone was going home.

Anwar collected his keys with his daughter. She put the ring on her finger and turned it while he listened to the information about the water. Denise wanted another inspection before accepting that the work inside her house was finished. Ruth asked which number to use if the electricity failed after the contractor left. The answer was on a sheet she had already been given, beneath something she had thought applied only to the shared building.

Eva read it with her. She drew a circle around it. [75]

Pat came through to check the room dates. The studio was booked again at the weekend. Eva would take the last bags back to Sun Court on Thursday and let Pat know the room was clear. Her meals were paid for; she had put the receipt in her wallet. [181]

A woman at the neighbouring table asked whether they were celebrating.

“Going home,” Anwar said.

“How lovely.”

He smiled at his daughter. [232] She told the woman there would be a new place to keep her bicycle, and began describing it. Eva had not heard about the bicycle store. It turned out to be a place Anwar had not yet agreed to build.

They left with the keys. Nessa cleared the table, finding one of the contact sheets beneath a plate. She put it on the sideboard. It

was the old number, but she did not know that until Eva came back to collect her bag.

Eva replaced the sheet and asked whether she should take the old one away.

"Please," Nessa said. "We've got enough things left here."

—

At Sun Court the new gate was open because Graham had been through to collect a tool. Eva asked him to close it. He did, then stayed beside the van while she approached from the path. The surface was dry. She stopped short of the latch, reached, and opened the gate. It stayed where she left it. She came through with the bag on her lap and closed it from the other side.

There was enough room.

She put the bag inside, came back out and tried the return journey. From the van Graham asked whether she wanted him to make it close itself. She said no. The gate had to stay open while she used it. He said all right and asked her to let him know if anything worked loose.

"Thank you," she said.

"What a pity you're going." [252]

"I'm using it now."

"You know what I mean."

"Yes."

He gathered up his tools. [192]

Eva went inside, and for the first hour she did very little. The people who had cleaned the house had put several things where they did not belong. It was still easier to reach them than it had been to reach many things at the hotel. She used the sink without thinking about the space beneath it. She opened the bathroom door with the movement she had taught herself eighteen years before. The latch caught in its familiar way. Someone had offered to change it and she had said not that one.

There was no milk, no butter. [25] She broke a corner off a piece of toast. [168]

Ruth rang from next door.

“Are you in?”

“Yes.”

“Can I come round?”

The garden gate was shut. [86] The corner of a cold frame. [8]

“Of course.”

Ruth went round by the front of her house and along the new path. She was carrying the blue bowl wrapped in a towel. Eva had forgotten it was at Ruth’s. It had been there before the fire and hadn’t been collected during the retrieval visits.

“I washed it.”

“Thanks.”

“The foot’s still useless.”

“It stands.”

“If you don’t touch it.”

Ruth had brought bread, but her freezer was still off. The freezer was empty. [160] Sliced bread, because you can toast it from frozen. [273]

They went next door to turn it on. Eva used the shared path and Ruth held her front door. Paint that did not quite match the old. [358] The floor was worn and scratchy. [62]

Ruth stood a moment [136] and switched it on. [19]

—

On the first Sunday back, they ate outside.

The tables went lengthways. There was room beside them for Eva to pass without asking anyone to stand. Ruth had put the bread over the join. Anwar’s daughter brought a bottle of something bright red and set it carefully at the end furthest from her father.

Leila arrived late with a dish she had not made. Nobody asked her to account for the journey. She sat where the afternoon light would not fall directly on her face. Tom moved a bowl nearer her and asked whether she wanted a drink. When she said not yet, he left the glass empty.

She was at home. [305]

Eva had brought the plates through the new gate. She had not needed Ruth to move anything. The cold frame stood where Ruth wanted it, and one end received too much sun. She complained about this while handing round strawberries. Eva told her to turn it round, knowing perfectly well why she could not.

The letter from the housing team lay beneath Leila's menu. Helen had confirmed which sentences could be used. Leila had answered a follow-up question in writing. There had been no telephone call to explain her answer to her.

At the table somebody had missed the last episode of a programme and did not want to know the ending. The conversation divided. Tom reached behind Eva's chair for the bottle. She turned and he stopped, asking where she wanted it. She took it from him. Later they would go inside and leave the plates until morning. His bag, with the clean shirt, was already in the bedroom.

Leila sat on the edge of her bed. [114]

Eva had sent Leila a photograph of the blue bowl, offering it before the move. Leila said no, it was too large. Eva replied, *Everyone keeps saying that.* There was no room for it. [6]

A taxi was waiting at the door. [195]

At Sun Court, the contractor's temporary fence divided the court. Eva ate the end of Ruth's loaf beside the screen. She had asked for the new gate and the restored services to be used in the Sunday. On the page the fence had gone too. The contractor was due to take it down the following week.

The moving company wanted the width of the shared passage. Eva copied the figure from Clare's drawing. The driver asked about the last turn. She brought the drawing over the paragraph in which Tom was still holding the bottle.

—

In fact she slept. [324]

But the next night [61] a muffled knocking sounded. [254] In the morning she found an empty container against the fence and moved it.

She worked at the [108] old walnut table, with one leaf up. [62] The client rang to confirm the catalogue updates. They agreed the tasks and the fee. She asked for the first files before moving day rather than on it. He promised they would arrive. By evening they had not, but the agreement was in writing and he had paid the previous invoice. She left the space for the new work in her calendar. At six she took an old photograph round to Ruth's garden.

The lid of the cold frame, [146] propped open with a stick. [107]

"It works."

"I haven't said anything."

"You were going to."

She held out the picture. [170]

The date on the back of the photograph. [295]

"Where did you get this?" Ruth asked.

"From you, presumably."

"I don't remember."

"Neither do I."

"I remember that suit." [37]

"Your mother looked happy."

"She was telling somebody to get out of the way."

"That can make people happy."

The earrings shaped like tiny pagodas. [203]

“I lost one of those at the pier.”

“The crab weekend?”

“You mean the weekend you spent sixteen pounds winning something they sold for four.”

“It wasn’t the same one.”

“It was exactly the same.”

All that fuss for a toy. [314]

“You said you liked it.”

“I did like it. It was hideous.”

She laughed and laughed, [11] letting the photograph fall. [141]

“Leave it,” Eva said, when Ruth bent for it. “I can get it from here.”

As she remembered it, [134] the girl’s warm lips brushed the angle of her jaw. [252]

“What happened to it?” Ruth asked.

“The crab?”

“Yes.”

“I don’t know where it is now.” [156]

“I’ll ask my sister,” Ruth said. “She takes things.” Then Ruth asked for a copy of the photograph.

Eva looked at the [277] picture in her hand. [141] She sent a photo. [212]

Ruth took a folded page from her pocket. The biopsy had been on Wednesday. Her sister had stayed the night. A note in her own handwriting. [101] Liver.

“What does it mean?” [224] Eva asked.

“I don’t know yet.” [292]

The page said the results would take several days. She read the same sentences over and over again. [274] She picked up the phone. [267] No missed calls. She put the papers aside. [208]

At the door Ruth asked whether Eva needed help on Monday.

“The movers are doing the heavy things.”

“That isn’t what I asked.”

"Some help with the kitchen would be good."

"At nine in the morning. [138] We have two hours." [92]

—

By the end of his first day, Tom had repaired nothing.

He had been issued equipment, shown his work areas and questioned about procedures he had just been taught. He would begin in offices, welfare rooms and stores, with a supervisor checking what he did.

His daughter had asked how the first day was going. He took a bite of his sandwich. [180] He sent her a photo. [233] She wrote back, "Well, look at you." [288]

The next day his supervisor took him to a faulty door. "I'll show you how if you like." [308] He loosened the screws. [31]

At five Laura rang the number on her printed instructions. She could not find the notes for a booking he had altered in his final week. He told her where to look. At six she rang to say she had found them, then asked another question. He answered that too. The third call came while he was buying food.

"Ask Pat," he said.

"She's with someone."

"I'm not there."

Laura said all right and rang off. At home he asked his daughter about the room she'd been to see. She said she liked it. [237] She texted him a photo. [98] A small room with a large bed. [189]

"It's the angle, Dad."

"Send another angle."

She took another picture [3] and sent it to him. [3]

On Saturday he went to Sun Court. Eva had left the new gate unlocked. He called before coming in. She was at the table, working through a set of pages which had finally arrived. There were boxes beside the wall and a bag of clothes on the bed. He

had brought sandwiches. [244] She looked at the bag, then at the time.

"I forgot."

"That's all right."

"No, I meant to stop."

She put the papers aside. [208] He opened the cupboard and got out two plates. [226] Over the sandwiches he told her about the door at work. He could take his time. [279]

His phone buzzed with a text message. [229] He did not answer. [189]

Eva opened the laptop to show him a photograph of the worktable. The Thursday was on the screen behind it. He read the first sentence before she changed windows.

"What's that?"

She put the Thursday back. He asked whether he could read it. She moved the cup out of the way and turned the screen toward him. [85]

He read it slowly. [34] She did not move. [326]

"When did you do this?"

"Before the dinner."

"Our dinner?"

"Yes."

"Christ."

He went back to the beginning. [336] He looked round him and then at her. [204] The table was where the page had put it. The boxes were not on the page.

"I spent that dinner trying not to talk about radiator valves," he said.

"You did talk about them."

"I know. For ages."

"I was interested."

He raised a questioning eyebrow. [313]

"Some of it."

"I could have written it myself." [276] He smiled a little nervously. [323]

"You've gone back to work."

"I do sometimes."

"While I'm there."

"Would you rather I didn't?"

"No. I like it."

She watched his face as he read. [341]

"Could you send it to me?"

"This one?"

"Yes."

"Why?"

"I'd like to read it without you looking at me."

She wiped her fingers with a napkin. [312] "All right."

He moved the laptop a little towards her but kept his hand on it. "Is there one for the flat?"

"For Alder Road. The other flat."

"Am I in it?"

"Yes."

"Can I read that?"

How well she remembered it: [11] he could not come that night. [24]

"Not now."

His hand came off the laptop.

"All right."

"Have some dinner with me?" [155]

"I haven't started the bedroom."

"I could bring something."

"Tom."

She laid her hand on his arm, left it there. [136] "I'd like it," she said. "Just not tonight."

They bent over the photograph together. [65] A tiny cupboard of a room. [91]

Eva had forgotten how the worktable came apart. The printed instructions were in a folder for a client who no longer existed. Tom supported one end of the extra section while she released the fixing. When it came away, there was a pale strip on the wall behind it. He asked whether she wanted it moved into another room.

"Leave it there for now."

He leaned it against the wall [258] on folded cardboard. She leaned forward and kissed him. [210] He asked her to send the route to Mercer Street, because his map had taken him to the front entrance. That evening she sent the route and the Thursday. He answered the Thursday first.

—

"You know the drawer." [24]

Tom read the line again in his kitchen. Eva had sent the first Thursday, which ended with him putting things down in the bedroom. In the writing window he had asked for another ordinary evening, with the new job and the longer drive. He had not asked for a drawer.

The drawer stuck because he pulled sideways. [189] He made the tea. [323] She read the same sentences over and over again. [274] He ran his eye over the receipt. [11]

He selected the address and typed Mercer Street. The first revision kept the old worktable and the view of Ruth's fence. He put in the single room, the alcove and the route she had sent. In the next version the drawer was beside her bed. She had made space for it.

Tom removed the sentence saying she was always pleased when he arrived. It sounded like a reason to come whenever he wanted. The drawer stayed. So did the tea.

He went out and bought [196] a new phone charger. [162] He left it in its packet on the passenger seat.

—

On Sunday evening, Eva opened *Current Arrangements* to remove herself as the first contact.

Anwar agreed to keep the general sheet updated if the household contacts checked their own entries. Naomi retained the private information; the owners took the maintenance schedule. Pat asked for hotel deliveries to be removed as soon as the households concerned had changed their accounts.

Eva sent the revised links. Two people asked her questions underneath the message telling them who should now receive questions. She answered one and forwarded the other. Then she went into her own delivery accounts and changed the address on each separately.

Her name remained in copies already sent. The contractor rang about the last gate adjustment. When the agent asked whether Denise had accepted an offer, Eva said she didn't know. She asked Denise afterwards, and Denise said she would tell her when there was something to tell.

Anwar's shorter sheet began with the new contacts. The print was very faint. [318] He asked Eva to mark only the changes. Her number was still at the bottom. She drew a circle around it. [75]

The moving company rang at eight. The driver had the width of the passage, but wanted to know whether they could come through Ruth's garden with one of the longer pieces. The old photo showed a clear route. His plan said *gate left open*. "It's usually left open."

"Use the new entrance," Eva said.

"Even for the table?"

"It comes apart. I've sent the measurements."

He opened the attachment and enlarged the image. [161] She wrapped the plates, one by one. [354]

9. A Different Address

And Ruth came in. [128] She had brought a knife.

Eva had packed her own. “Lend me your knife.” [221]

“Yes, here it is.” [27] She handed it to her. [325]

“Shall I put the kettle on?” [120]

They had tea.

The path was dry. [246]

Ruth asked where the bowl was going.

“With me.”

“You’ve wrapped it?”

“Yes.”

“The foot—”

“I know.”

They both laughed a little. [191]

Ruth went to the door. [259] “Call me if you need anything.” [131]

Eva thanked her. Ruth came back for her glasses, which were beside the kettle, then left by the shared path.

The movers arrived at eleven fifteen. There were two men, one carrying a folder and the other examining the passage without pretending to know its width by looking. They had the measurements. They wanted to see which end of the table came apart.

“It’s already apart.”

“Lovely.”

They began with the largest pieces. Eva stayed where she could answer questions without blocking the route. When the men

needed the space where she was waiting, they said so and she moved.

Hold-alls, bags and boxes were piled upon the floor. “These are absolute necessities that I will not let out of my sight for one instant.” [204]

The man with the folder put his hand on the old gate’s latch. He could see the shorter route through Ruth’s garden.

“Not that way,” Eva said.

“All right.”

He turned back to the new path. Eva drew it on his copy. They had priced the work on the measurements she supplied.

Graham walked to her side. [58] “Good luck, then.”

“Thank you. For the chair as well.”

“That was Leila’s.”

“I know.”

He checked his phone. [257]

The taxi came into sight. [203] The driver put the bag up in front. [148]

Then she locked the door. [304]

—

In Mercer Street the men put the table where she asked, then moved it when she saw what it prevented.

The alcove had been measured without the skirting. They brought the table forward so the lead could pass behind it. Eva tried the narrower turn, asked for another adjustment and apologised.

“No trouble at all.” [30]

She checked the clock and asked them to leave the second bookcase in pieces. The man collecting unwanted furniture could not come until later in the week; she had brought it rather than pay for another collection from Sun Court.

The movers left the boxes she needed first within reach. She checked the larger pieces and paid the agreed amount plus the charge for the extra time.

The movers had gone. [126]

Eva rang Leila. It went to voicemail. [110] She sent a photograph of the boxes with the message *In. You don't have to do anything.*

Leila answered an hour later.

I know. Do you want milk?

She put the kettle on. [292]

The trumpet sounded again. [179]

—

That afternoon, Ruth lost two games and won the third.

She went out into the garden. [191]

Why should not this one spot be kept exclusively for her? She liked it; she liked it best of all. [11]

She sat in the deck chair. [344]

A woman's voice spoke. [87] "The way to the sea?" [230]

"Go round by the road." [26] She put the watering can down. [159]

When the text came through, it was a picture. [70]

"Have you had tea?" [203]

The hospital rang. A woman's voice spoke. [87] Results. The following Monday. She wrote it down. [164] On a seed packet.

She turned it over in her hand. [79]

A call from Ruth. [227] Eva picked up the phone. [267]

"I want to ask you a favour." [128]

The hospital. Monday. Eva said yes. She wrote it down. [164]

—

Eva went back to the kitchen. [166]

Then she called Ruth. [124] Eva said the flat was too warm, though the heating was off.

“Open the window a little wider.” [82]
“The window is open.” [73]
“Well, I don’t know.” [196]
At the same moment, they said good-bye. [323]
She woke up and [325] put out her hand. [94] The chair beside her. [72]
She was in the kitchen, [321] cutting the string with scissors. [195]

—

On the screen, the workroom was cool until noon.
She closed the door. [133] She went back to her work. [309]
At the print shop, [194] she looked at the photograph. [264]
Kit gave her a sheet of peculiarly rough paper. [310]
She picked up her pen. [290] She began to draw. [193]
A call from Ruth. [227] She picked up the phone. [267]
She went back to her drawing. [81]
A potted geranium on the window sill. [270]

—

In Mercer Street Eva had to clear the worktable in the sitting room for a second person to eat. The plant had not arrived. She opened the trolley listing saved beneath the Sunday and checked its width.

For herself, Eva could sit at the end and move the keyboard. She bought a trolley with two shelves and spent an afternoon deciding which things could go on it. The lower shelf was difficult to reach with the trolley beside the table. She asked the seller whether it could be removed. It could. The seller sent a photograph of where the fixings were, which was more useful than the instruction sheet.

She took the shelf off. The trolley was less stable when empty but worked with the weight distributed differently. She put the instruction sheet in a folder.

The first printed proofs went to Sun Court.

The address on her account had changed, but the address on the order had not. Ruth accepted the parcel because the driver had already carried it to her door and Eva's name was visible on the label. It was heavier than it looked. [41] She left it on a chair in the kitchen and rang.

"I need it gone before Friday."

"I'll arrange something."

"The man said you lived next door."

"I still own it."

"That isn't what he said."

The supplier could collect from Ruth on Thursday and deliver on Friday. The client wanted corrections on Thursday.

The assisted draft explained the delivery delay and asked to move the deadline for corrections to Friday. Eva read it and sent it. The reply came quickly. [78] "Friday will be fine." [171] The parcel remained on Ruth's kitchen chair until Thursday afternoon.

The next order showed Mercer Street. Beneath it, under If no reply, was Ruth's number. Eva asked for that to be removed too. The supplier sent another confirmation.

Eva worked on the digital pages. The papers lay on the table, [204] covered with a cloth. [203]

She went into the shop [52] to buy a loaf of bread. [225]

—

Tom arrived on Thursday before she had finished. He was holding a bag. [21] "I'll cook dinner tonight." [16]

"I can't have this room changed if I'm going to work here." [62]

"The kitchen's still full of things."

"I'll move them."

"Please don't."

He put the bag on the floor. [71] "I thought it would help."

"I need to finish."

She had lost her place. [353]

He went out into the court. He buttoned his jacket across his chest. [324]

At seven they began making food. He asked before putting anything away. She showed him which cupboard could take the things he had bought, and which part of the counter needed to remain clear.

They ate at eight. He told her about the induction instructor, who had called him Tim all morning while the man actually called Tim sat beside him. “Neither of us answered by the end.”

Eva laughed, then looked at the covered papers. She had sent the page without checking the footer.

“Are you listening?”

“Mostly.”

“Brilliant.”

“I’m sorry. What did the other Tim do?”

“Tom.”

“What?”

“The other one was Tom by then.”

She burst out laughing again. [144] He waited, eating, and when she had stopped he told her the instructor had thanked them both for their participation.

“I’m going to ask for Tim’s pay.”

“Find out what it is first.”

They sat side by side. [191]

“I didn’t bring a toothbrush—” [359]

“You can leave some things here.”

He opened his mouth. [265]

“Not now,” she said. “Another time.”

“No need to hurry.” [303]

Neither took out a phone to settle which time. He kissed her goodbye, [286] then returned for the bag he had meant to take home. She gave him a container of the remaining food and asked him to bring the container back when he came again.

The key on the hook. [322] He had a spare charger. [90]

—

On Friday Leila came for twenty minutes.

She had planned it for the afternoon and sent a message in the morning saying she would try. Eva did not prepare food. She made sure there was somewhere to sit and that the way to the bathroom was clear. She had not needed to move a box to make that true since Wednesday.

She opened the magazine. [129] "Interviews" plastered with pictures. [196] An actor was talking about his film.

"One subject—his own doings," [201] Leila said.

"Three expressions, Joy, Sorrow, and Indigestion." [200]

"I like him very much." [15]

"You haven't seen it yet." [28]

"But I like his face." [152]

Turning the page, she came upon the picture. [323] A man fallen from a horse. [168]

"There's rather a lot of chiaroscuro, isn't there?" [168]

"I like the man and the horse; don't you?" [168] She held it at arm's length. [185] "Can you read the rest for me?" [315]

"Here, give it to me." [199]

"Don't tell me he's wonderful. I've just read six pages of him saying it."

At the door Leila said, "I have to get back." [204]

When she reached home, [24] she lay down on her bed. [112]

When the visitor had departed, [285] she looked at the proofs. [198]

10. The Next Sunday

The fence was gone. [116]

She went back to the house. [112] The passage remained clear. [348]

The agent had drafted the particulars from photographs and the information Eva sent. He wanted to call the house accessible throughout. She asked him not to. The front entrance still had a step. The kitchen worked for her, but that did not mean it worked for every person he might bring to see it.

“What would you say?” [113]

“The width of the corridor. [24] The dimensions of the room.” [304]

Eva added, “Bigger in the photograph than it really is.” [112]

“Do you have to [283] go through the garden?” [15]

“No, not at all.” [117] She unfolded the map. [297]

No one had made an offer. [337] He turned to go. [306]

There was a man [323] at the back door, [125] with hammer and nails. [72]

“I don’t understand it,” [86] Anwar said.

“Here, give it to me.” [199]

He held up the instructions. [47] Eva took the sheet to Denise.

Denise opened the door. [342] “We’ve accepted his offer. [263] Will you be here on Sunday?” [293]

“I can’t stay long.” [278]

“It won’t be anything fancy.” [345]

“I’ll bring the bread.” [355]

—

A little table near one of the open windows. [204] Olha was there with her mother, who had arrived from Ukraine the previous week. Nessa had collected them from the coach. Between the cups was a railway timetable covered in Olha's small circles. The old woman paused. [203] She ran her finger down [347] the column of numbers. [69]

"And that's as far as you go?" [196]

"To the end of the line." [172]

She looked at the timetable. [209]

"Is there anywhere to eat?" [349]

"I can find out." [27]

They kept their attention on what they were doing. [113]

"How do you like your new flat?" [239] Olha asked.

"I'm still unpacking from the move." [351]

"There's always something else." [328]

The waitress came back [203] and began to clear the table. [134]

Eva asked Nessa about the photograph of the hotel. "Do you get many calls?" [234]

"Sometimes, but not very often." [115]

Eva turned from the window. [282] She set a keycard on the bar. [248] "I'll have a coffee." [204]

Ruth stood in the doorway. [328]

"Have you eaten?"

"I haven't eaten yet." [241]

"They do a smaller one now."

"What?"

"The breakfast. That's what I'm having." [55]

They had breakfast together. [77]

She took up her cue. [231] The table was bad. [236]

—

Eva Shaw had returned to Sun Court following repairs. The independent route had been completed and her hotel placement ended. When Naomi rang to check the dates, Eva was at home in Mercer Street, with the trolley beside her and the trumpet audible from the other courtyard.

"I did go back." [245]

"I have it here." [157]

"I spent six nights." [32]

"And what happened then?" [321]

After she checked the dates, [106] she found the receipt. [220] They finally came to an understanding. [121]

"I'll give you the number." [49]

"Thank you so much." [189]

She hung up the phone. [284]

—

Leila read the pages. [114] She closed the bedroom door. [25] She lay down on the bed. [272]

There was a knock at the door [72] when they brought the groceries. [61]

The peaches and the pears, [204] waiting in the fridge. [352]

There was a picture: [202] the swollen old dog lolling on a bead cushion. [204]

She picked up a book. [25] A note in her own handwriting. [101] She sent her friend a picture of the note. The reply showed the dog sharing the cushion with a coat. She laughed. "Well, that's one way." [113]

—

The loaves of bread. [61] They had more than enough. [211]

Sliced bread, because you can toast it from frozen. [273]

The tables did not match. They were arranged differently from the ones in the account: one against the wall and one further into the court, with a clear way between them. People moved their chairs to talk and then had to move them back. Eva asked a man she did not know to leave a little more room behind him. He apologised and moved too far. She said where would be enough.

Graham looked at their faces. [301] The man and woman drew near the camera. [158]

"It would add human interest." [158]

"I don't want to [56] have my photograph taken." [302]

"You needn't if you don't want." [245]

Graham turned the camera away from Eva. A snap-shot at short range. [158] "This is what actually happened." [61]

"So much of it as we can see from here." [18]

He began to write. [168] He read it over before posting it. [350]

She was looking at plans. [118] To be let furnished for the month. [11]

Ruth came in with [128] a plate in her hands. [130]

"Look here, you've got nothing to eat." [325]

"I haven't. At least, hardly anything." [11]

"Have some of this." [217]

She took a large bite of pie. [251]

"A good view of the sea [153] from the café window." [33]

"The small bathroom window." [218]

"That was the one." [203]

A child came in on an errand. [54] "What would you like?" [221] She took their orders. [17]

Leila wrote a short note. [114] *I can't be there.* [189]

"An absurdly easy stroke. [320] The cue slid off." [320]

Ruth caught her smiling. "Why are you laughing?" [23]

"It's finer as a story." [111]

"Did I really say that?" [321]

"Yes, that was it." [191]

“I like that much better.” [321]

They were laughing more and more. [11]

“That pot of geraniums.” [280] A small plant in the track of a ray of sunshine. [24] “You can have it if you want to.” [1]

“Where shall I put it?” [253]

“Over by the window.” [39]

“That narrows it down.” [207]

She opened the new gate. [134]

A taxi was too expensive. [291]

A basket of strawberries. [203] Denise put some into a smaller container for Eva.

At the stop Ruth checked the bag with the plant. “Shall I shift it?” [294]

“Thursday?” Ruth said.

“What do you mean?” [323]

“The book. I’ll give it back.” [222]

She had forgotten it. [118]

“Come and see me.” [109]

“To tea, if that suits you?” [323]

“At three in the afternoon.” [197]

The wheelchair ramp came out. [74]

—

She set the small plant on the windowsill, [104] but it was too close to the curtain. She stuck it in the kitchen. [262]

She was reading proofs. [346]

The table was cleared. [176] There was room for her. [304]

Tom sent a message. [298] A photograph of his daughter. [299] He asked about Tuesday.

“I’ll come at seven.” [240] She wrote it down. [164]

11. There was work to be done [53]

There was the usual waiting. [331] A little table near one of the open windows. [204] She waited in silence. [189]

And Ruth came in. [128]

“I have it here.” [157]

She took the book. [94] She handed it to her. [325]

They went into another room. [20]

“Won’t you come in and sit down?” [176]

“I can wait outside.” [317]

Ruth stood in the doorway. [328]

“Do stay a little longer.” [67]

There was a picture. [202]

Ruth looked at it. [136]

“Let me read it.” [203]

In stage IV, the tumor is any size, and cancer has spread to other parts of the body, such as the liver. [333]

Unfortunately, treatment won’t cure stage 4 pancreatic cancer. [332]

She read the same sentences over and over again. [274] She needed more time. [307]

“Can you read the rest for me?” [315]

Eva turned from the window. [282]

“Here, give it to me.” [199]

But it might help you live longer and relieve symptoms. [332]

Ruth looked at it. [136] She picked up her pen. [290] She wrote it down. [164] A note in her own handwriting. [101]

The doctor said: [331] “I’ll give you the number.” [49]

Ruth stood a moment. [136] She picked up her coat. [275]

They stopped; they waited for each other. [203]

A taxi was waiting at the door. [195] They sat side by side. [191]

They sat in the kitchen. [105]

“Shall I put the kettle on?” [120]

“Yes, I’ll have some tea.” [137]

Ruth stood in the doorway. [328]

“Come and see me.” [109]

“Friday will be fine.” [171]

“To tea, if that suits you?” [323]

“At three in the afternoon.” [197]

—

The path was dry. [246] Ruth stood in the doorway. [328]

“I’m so glad to see you.” [108]

She went out into the garden. [191] The lid of the cold frame, [146] propped open with a stick. [107] The sound of the sea was a vague murmur. [203]

Ruth stood a moment. [136] She put the watering can down. [159]

“Something has eaten almost all of my tender young lettuce.” [97]

“Can I help you?” [188]

“No, not at all.” [117]

She was at home. [305] Why should not this one spot be kept exclusively for her? [11]

“I want to ask you a favour. [128] Will you be here on Sunday?” [293]

“I can’t stay long.” [278]

“It won’t be anything fancy.” [345]

“I’ll bring the bread.” [355]

They sat side by side. [191] There was not much said on either side. [95]

They laughed a little together, quietly. [283]

“Shall I put the kettle on?” [120]

"Yes, I'll have some tea." [137]

She went back to the house. [112] She put the kettle on. [292]

—

On Sunday, [293] Eva went back to [166] the house. [112] A loaf of bread. [225]

Ruth's sister [360] opened the door. [342] "Here, give it to me." [199]

She put it in the freezer. [361]

—

Leila sat on the edge of her bed. [114]

She dictated the message. [167]

"Have some dinner with me?" [155]

She sent it off. [165]

Eva looked down at [173] the message she had just received. [149]

She looked at the map and marked where she had been. [297]

She took her bag and went. [240]

The soup was ready. [154]

"Won't you come in and sit down?" [176]

"I'm so glad to see you." [108]

They ate in near silence. [183]

The soup was thick and tasty. [216]

She opened the book. [117] There were often pencilled notes in the margin. [133]

"Did you write this?" [189]

"I don't remember now." [72]

"What does it mean?" [224]

"I don't know yet." [292]

She wanted to lie down. [100]

"Do stay a little longer." [67]

"You needn't get up." [44]

"I am quite happy." [323]

She carried the dishes to the sink. [80]

She took the book, [94] the bedroom door half open. [164]

"Shall I close that window over there?" [113]

"At least part of the way." [83]

She closed the [133] window [73] part of the way. [83] Eva turned from the window. [282] She opened the book. [117]

She read that first line again. [252]

References

[1] Eleanor Hallowell Abbott. 2004. *The White Linen Nurse*. Project Gutenberg eBook 14506. Originally published in 1913. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/14506

[2] Lyman Abbott. 2004. *Laicus; Or, the Experiences of a Layman in a Country Parish.* Project Gutenberg eBook 4954. Originally published in 1872. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/4954

[3] Haifa Abualnadi. 2018. Brownies With a Taste of Longing. In *Propositions*. University of Iowa International Writing Program. p. 3. Translated by Elisabeth Jaquette. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://iwp.uiowa.edu/sites/iwp.uiowa.edu/files/2024-06/Abualnadi%20English_formatted.pdf

[4] Chimamanda Ngozi Adichie. 2013. *Americanah*. Alfred A. Knopf. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://eclass.uoa.gr/modules/document/file.php/ENL403/Novels/Americanah%20Chimamanda_Ngozi_Adichie.pdf

[5] Nicole Alexander. 2020. *The Cedar Tree*. Penguin Books Australia. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://www.penguin.com.au/books/the-cedar-tree-9780143786863/extracts/2228-the-cedar-tree

[6] Anonymous. 2013. *Punch, or the London Charivari, Vol. 105, October 14th 1893*. Project Gutenberg eBook 44020. Includes “Bobo (The Kind of Novel Society Likes)”. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/44020

[7] Arthur Applin. 2013. *Blackthorn Farm*. Project Gutenberg eBook 42519. Originally published in 1915. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/42519

[8] Reginald Arkell. 2011. *Old Herbaceous*. Project Gutenberg Canada eBook arkellr-oldherbaceous. Originally published in 1950. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://gutenberg.ca/ebooks/arkellr-oldherbaceous/arkellr-oldherbaceous-01-h-dir/arkellr-oldherbaceous-01-h.html

[9] Charlotte Armstrong. 2024. *The Protégé*. Distributed Proofreaders Canada (Faded Page) eBook 20241215. Originally published in 1970. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://www.fadedpage.com/showbook.php?pid=20241215

[10] Charlotte Armstrong. 2026. *Seven Seats to the Moon*. Distributed Proofreaders Canada (Faded Page) eBook 20261005. Originally published in 1969. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://www.fadedpage.com/showbook.php?pid=20261005

[11] Elizabeth von Arnim. 2005. *The Enchanted April*. Project Gutenberg eBook 16389. Originally published in 1922. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/16389

[12] Elizabeth von Arnim. 2009. *The Benefactress*. Project Gutenberg eBook 30302. Originally published in 1901. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/30302

[13] Anne Austin. 2011. *Girl Alone*. Project Gutenberg eBook 35077. Originally published in 1928. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/35077

[14] Irving Bacheller. 2004. *The Light in the Clearing: A Tale of the North Country in the Time of Silas Wright*. Project Gutenberg eBook 14150. Originally published in 1917. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/14150

[15] Richard Bagot. 2014. *The Passport*. Project Gutenberg eBook 46693. Originally published in 1905. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/46693

[16] Frankie Y. Bailey. 2013. *The Red Queen Dies*. Minotaur Books. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://us.macmillan.com/books/9781250037176/theredqueendies/

[17] Tom Barbash. 2018. *The Last Good Chance*. Open Road Integrated Media. Originally published in 2002. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://www.everand.com/book/726469425/The-Last-Good-Chance-A-Novel

[18] Henri Barbusse. 2003. *Under Fire: The Story of a Squad*. Project Gutenberg eBook 4380. Translated by W. Fitzwater Wray (1917). Originally published in 1916. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/4380

[19] Emily Barr. 2023. *This Summer's Secrets*. Penguin Books. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://cdn.penguin.co.uk/dam-assets/books/9780241481905/9780241481905-sample.pdf

[20] Ludwig Bechstein. 2024. The Quiet Folk of Plesse. In *Book of German Legends*. p. 468. Translated by Michael Haldane. Originally published in 1853. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://michaelhaldane.com/Bechstein%27s%20Book%20of%20German%20Legends.pdf

[21] Gabrielle Bellot. 2020. The Cruel and Astonishing Tale. *McSweeney's Quarterly Concern*. Issue 62, The Queer Fiction Issue. pp. 166–167. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://d3thpuk46eyjbu.cloudfront.net/uploads/production/4778/1602627652/original/mcs62_interior14_spreads.pdf?1602627652=

[22] Barry Benefield. 2026. Miss Willett. In *The Best Short Stories of 1916, and the Yearbook of the American Short Story*, edited by Edward J. O'Brien. Project Gutenberg eBook 79656. Story first published in 1916. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/79656

[23] Arnold Bennett. 2004. *Mr. Prohack*. Project Gutenberg eBook 12773. Originally published in 1922. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/12773

[24] Arnold Bennett. 2004. *The Old Wives' Tale*. Project Gutenberg eBook 5247. Originally published in 1908. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/5247

[25] Arnold Bennett. 2019. *Riceyman Steps: A Novel*. Project Gutenberg eBook 58666. Originally published in 1923. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/58666

[26] E. F. Benson. 2004. *Queen Lucia*. Project Gutenberg eBook 6840. Originally published in 1920. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/6840

[27] E. F. Benson. 2005. *Paying Guests*. Project Gutenberg Australia eBook 0501221. Originally published in 1929. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://gutenberg.net.au/ebooks05/0501221h.html

[28] E. F. Benson. 2008. *Miss Mapp*. Project Gutenberg eBook 25919. Originally published in 1922. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/25919

[29] Stella Benson. 2005. *Living Alone*. Project Gutenberg eBook 14907. Originally published in 1919. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/14907

[30] Flora E. Berry. 2014. *Monica's Choice*. Project Gutenberg eBook 45432. Originally published in 1904. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/45432

[31] Leslie Bessant. 2005. Cay De Amour. *Futures Mystery Anthology Magazine*. September–October 2005 issue. p. 67. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://twilighttimesbooks.com/ebooks/fmam_Sept05_4.pdf

[32] Maeve Binchy. 2016. Picnic at St. Paul's. In *A Few of the Girls*. Knopf. Originally published in 2015. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://www.everand.com/book/769887428/A-Few-of-the-Girls-Stories

[33] Juraj Bindzár. 2017. Today Too. In *Books from Slovakia 2017*. Slovak Literary Centre. p. 5. Translated by Heather Trebatická. Excerpt from *Mlčky a krátko* (2016). Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://www.litcentrum.sk/sites/default/files/catalogue_issue_files/2017_bfs.pdf#page=5

[34] William Black. 2013. *White Heather: A Novel (Volume 2 of 3)*. Project Gutenberg eBook 43445. Originally published in 1885. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/43445

[35] Haili Blassingame. 2026. *They All Fall in Love at the End*. Simon & Schuster. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://www.simonandschuster.com/books/They-All-Fall-in-Love-at-the-End/Haili-Blassingame/9781668204122

[36] Geraldine Bonner. 2022. *Tomorrow's Tangle*. Project Gutenberg eBook 67521. Originally published in 1903. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/67521

[37] Marie Bostwick. 2023. *Esme Cahill Fails Spectacularly*. William Morrow. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://harlequinjunkie.com/spotlight-giveaway-esme-cahill-fails-spectacularly-by-marie-bostwick/

[38] Elizabeth Bowen. 2026. *The last September*. Project Gutenberg eBook 79073. Originally published in 1929. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/79073

[39] Catherine Boyd. 2018. *Somebody's Knockin'*. Catherine Boyd. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://www.everand.com/book/376622481/Somebody-s-Knockin

[40] T. Coraghessan Boyle. n.d. I Dated Jane Austen. *The Northridge Review*. Originally published in *The Georgia Review* (1979). Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://journals.calstate.edu/nr/article/download/4840/3886/14624

[41] Tom Bradley. 2019. *The Screaming Tree*. p. 51. Originally published in 1994. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://www.bradley.nz/BOOKS/YAF/The%20Screaming%20Tree%20WEBSITE%20content/The%20Screaming%20Tree.pdf

[42] Allison Brennan. 2018. *Too Far Gone*. Minotaur Books. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://us.macmillan.com/books/9781250311856/toofargone/

[43] Catharine Brody. 2026. *West of Fifth*. Project Gutenberg eBook 77749. Originally published in 1930. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/77749

[44] Alice Brown. 2005. *Meadow Grass: Tales of New England Life*. Project Gutenberg eBook 9367. Includes "At Sudleigh Fair". Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/9367

[45] Mary Grant Bruce. 2016. *'Possum*. Project Gutenberg eBook 50881. Originally published in 1917. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/50881

[46] Megan E. Bryant. 2022. *Ready or Not!* Penguin Workshop. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://www.penguinrandomhouseretail.com/book/?isbn=9780593226520

[47] W. Bryant. 2023. Buried Treasure. *The Echo*. August 2023 issue. p. 24. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://texashistory.unt.edu/ark:/67531/metapth1721089/m2/1/high_res_d/August-2023-ECHO-fixed.pdf

[48] John Buchan. 1996. *Greenmantle*. Project Gutenberg eBook 559. Originally published in 1916. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/559

[49] John Buchan. 1996. *Mr. Standfast*. Project Gutenberg eBook 560. Originally published in 1919. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/560

[50] Taslim Burkowicz. 2022. *Ruby Red Skies*. Roseway Publishing. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://fernwoodpublishing.ca/files/Ruby-Red-Skies_Ex.pdf

[51] Frances Hodgson Burnett. 1994. *The Secret Garden*. Project Gutenberg eBook 113. Originally published in 1911. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/113

[52] Frances Hodgson Burnett. 2006. *Sara Crewe; Or, What Happened at Miss Minchin's Boarding School*. Project Gutenberg eBook 137. Originally published in 1888. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/137

[53] Frances Hodgson Burnett. 2006. *The Shuttle*. Project Gutenberg eBook 506. Originally published in 1907. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/506

[54] Samuel Butler. 2000. *The Way of All Flesh*. Project Gutenberg eBook 2084. Originally published in 1903. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/2084

[55] Sarah Butler. 2015. Amber Warning. In *Weatherfronts: Climate Change and the Stories We Tell*. TippingPoint. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://www.tippingpoint.org.uk/assets/public/files/Weathfronts_Commissions_Publication_2015.pdf

[56] Abraham Cahan. 2001. *The Rise of David Levinsky*. Project Gutenberg eBook 2803. Originally published in 1917. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/2803

[57] W. Bruce Cameron. 2020. *Lily to the Rescue: The Not-So-Stinky Skunk*. Starscape. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://us.macmillan.com/books/9781250234476/lilytotherescuethenotsostinkyskunk/

[58] Wadsworth Camp. 2004. *The Abandoned Room*. Project Gutenberg eBook 10869. Originally published in 1917. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/10869

[59] Karel Čapek. 2022. Keep the Receipt. *a śort spel*. Translated by Frank Johnson. Originally published in 1929. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://ashortspell.com/from-czech-keep-the-receipt-by-karel-capek/

[60] Melody Carlson. 2012. *Westward Hearts*. Harvest House Publishers. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://www.harvesthousepublishers.com/data/files/excerpts/9780736948715_exc.pdf

[61] Willa Cather. 2008. *My Ántonia*. Project Gutenberg eBook 242. Originally published in 1918. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/242

[62] Willa Cather. 2021. *The Professor's House*. Project Gutenberg eBook 65465. Originally published in 1925. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/65465

[63] Willa Cather. 2026. *My mortal enemy*. Project Gutenberg eBook 78501. Originally published in 1926. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/78501

[64] Katherine Catmull. 2016. *The Radiant Road*. Dutton Books for Young Readers. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://www.penguinteen.com/9781101600283/the-radiant-road/

[65] Robert W. Chambers. 2004. *The Tracer of Lost Persons*. Project Gutenberg eBook 13180. Originally published in 1906. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/13180

[66] James Hadley Chase. n.d. *Strictly for Cash*. Originally published in 1951. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://jhchase.ru/media/novels/books/books_eng_pdf/Eng_-_James_Hadley_Chase_-_Strictly_For_Cash.pdf

[67] Anton Chekhov. 2004. *The Duel and Other Stories*. Project Gutenberg eBook 13505. Translated by Constance Garnett (1916). Includes “At Home”. Story first published in 1897. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/13505

[68] Anton Chekhov. 2004. *The Party and Other Stories*. Project Gutenberg eBook 13413. Translated by Constance Garnett (1917). Includes “A Woman’s Kingdom”. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/13413

[69] Anton Chekhov. 2006. *The Wife, and Other Stories*. Project Gutenberg eBook 1883. Translated by Constance Garnett (1918). Includes “The Lottery Ticket”. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/1883

[70] Anelise Chen. 2025. Bird Strike. *The Atlantic*. February 25, 2025. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://www.theatlantic.com/culture/archive/2025/02/anelise-chen-bird-strike-short-story/681817/?utm_source=apple_news

[71] Donald Barr Chidsey. 1937. Midsummer Murders. *Detective Fiction Weekly*. June 19, 1937. p. 21. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://electronicsandbooks.com/edt/manual/Old%20Pulp%20Magazines/Detective%20Fiction%20Weekly/Detective%20Fiction%20Weekly%20-%2019%20June%201937.pdf

[72] Kate Chopin. 2006. *The Awakening, and Selected Short Stories*. Project Gutenberg eBook 160. Includes *The Awakening* (1899) and “A Respectable Woman” (1894). Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/160

[73] Agatha Christie. 2022. *The Murder of Roger Ackroyd*. Project Gutenberg eBook 69087. Originally published in 1926. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/69087

[74] Chris Clarkson (c.c. rider). 2013. Moving Forward. Booksie. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://www.booksie.com/554227-moving-forward

[75] Colleen Coble. 2020. *One Little Lie*. Thomas Nelson. p. 104. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://cr-assets.localretailconnect.com/preview/9780785228448.pdf

[76] H. A. Cody. 2016. *The Touch of Abner*. Project Gutenberg eBook 53604. Originally published in 1919. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/53604

[77] Joseph Conrad. 2006. *Tales of Unrest*. Project Gutenberg eBook 1202. Includes “The Return”. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/1202

[78] Michael J. Cooper. 2023. Interview with Evan Sinclair from Wages of Empire. Novel PASTimes. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://novelpastimes.com/2023/12/02/interview-with-evan-sinclair-from-wages-of-empire-by-michael-j-cooper/

[79] Benjamin Cors. n.d. *A Murder of Crows*. dtv Verlagsgesellschaft. p. 6. Translated by Lesley Schuldt. German original *Krähentage* (2024). Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://www.dtv.de/media/67/86/f1/1716444061/Cors_Krhentage_ST.pdf

[80] Alice Elliott Dark. 1993. In the Gloaming. *The New Yorker*. May 3, 1993 issue. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://www.newyorker.com/magazine/1993/05/03/in-the-gloaming

[81] Charles Paul de Kock. 1902. *Sister Anne*. Frederick J. Quinby. p. 72. Translated by Mary Hanford Ford. Originally published in 1825. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://upload.wikimedia.org/wikipedia/commons/e/e2/The_works_of_Charles_Paul_de_Kock_%28IA_cu31924088399948%29.pdf

[82] Pauline Delabroy-Allard. 2020. *They Say Sarah*. Other Press. Translated by Adriana Hunter. Originally published in 2018. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://otherpress.com/product/they-say-sarah-9781635429855/excerpt/

[83] E. M. Delafield. 2011. *The War-Workers*. Project Gutenberg eBook 37181. Originally published in 1918. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/37181

[84] E. M. Delafield. 2022. *The Optimist*. Project Gutenberg eBook 68524. Originally published in 1922. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/68524

[85] J. R. DeVoe. 2020. *Onero’s Hunt*. Dark Tide Publishing. p. 23. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://booklife.com/download-excerpt/binary-data/PROJECT/excerpt/000/087/87185-2.pdf

[86] Charles Dickens. 1996. *The Pickwick Papers*. Project Gutenberg eBook 580. Originally published in 1837. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/580

[87] Charles Dickens. 1998. *The Seven Poor Travellers*. Project Gutenberg eBook 1392. Originally published in 1854. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/1392

[88] Mary Angela Dickens. 2017. *A Valiant Ignorance; vol. 1 of 3*. Project Gutenberg eBook 54093. Originally published in 1894. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/54093

[89] Cory Doctorow. 2008. *Little Brother*. Tor Books. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://craphound.com/littlebrother/Cory_Doctorow_-_Little_Brother.txt

[90] Cory Doctorow. 2010. *For the Win*. Tor Books. p. 132. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://craphound.com/ftw/Cory_Doctorow_-_For_the_Win.pdf

[91] Fyodor Dostoevsky. 2006. *Crime and Punishment*. Project Gutenberg eBook 2554. Translated by Constance Garnett (1914). Originally published in 1866. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/2554

[92] Arthur Conan Doyle. 2002. *The Hound of the Baskervilles*. Project Gutenberg eBook 3070. Originally published in 1902. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/3070

[93] Theodore Dreiser. 2003. *The Titan*. Project Gutenberg eBook 3629. Originally published in 1914. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/3629

[94] W. E. B. Du Bois. 2005. *The Quest of the Silver Fleece: A Novel*. Project Gutenberg eBook 15265. Originally published in 1911. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/15265

[95] Alice Moore Dunbar-Nelson. 1996. *The Goodness of St. Rocque, and Other Stories*. Project Gutenberg eBook 688. Originally published in 1899. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/688

[96] Sara Jeannette Duncan. 2004. *The Imperialist*. Project Gutenberg eBook 5301. Originally published in 1904. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/5301

[97] Fannie Wyche Dunn and Eleanor Troxell. 1928. The Toads That Took a Trip. In *By the Roadside*. Row, Peterson and Company, Evanston, Illinois. p. 23. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://en.wikisource.org/wiki/User:SnowyCinema/P/By_the_Roadside_(Dunn_and_Troxell)

[98] Mary Duquette. 2020. Alice and Juno in Hell. *The Good Life Review*. Issue 1, Autumn 2020. p. 12. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://thegoodlifereview.com/wp-content/uploads/2020/10/GLR-Issue-One-Autumn-2020.pdf

[99] Jonathan Durbin. 2016. Cough. *The Masters Review*. Volume V. pp. 80–81. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://mastersreview.com/files/2016/10/FINAL_Volume-V.pdf

[100] Chester Eagle. 2013. *Swinging Doors*. Trojan Press. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://www.trojanpress.com.au/wp-content/uploads/2019/05/Swinging-Doors-Book.pdf

[101] Maria Edgeworth. 2003. *The Parent's Assistant; Or, Stories for Children*. Project Gutenberg eBook 3655. Includes “The False Key”. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/3655

[102] Crystal Squires Ellwood. 2019. *Chew: Selections from a Novel*. MA thesis. Western Carolina University. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://libres.uncg.edu/ir/wcu/f/Ellwood2019.pdf

[103] Lori Ericson. 2016. *A Lovely Murder*. Pen-L Publishing. p. 101. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://pen-l.com/Books/ALovelyMurder/ALovelyMurder-ARC.pdf

[104] Penelope Evans. 2015. Plant Life. *The Spectatorial*. Volume III. p. 11. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://thespectatorial.ca/wp-content/uploads/2024/11/vol-iii-online-version.pdf

[105] Percival Everett. 2017. Little Faith. *The Literary Review*. 60(3), Fall 2017. pp. 243–244. Originally published in 2012. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://www.mtoptoz.com/wp-content/uploads/2025/10/TLR_Current-Events_Fall-2017.pdf

[106] Hanns Heinz Ewers. 2025. *Fundvogel*. Lulu. Translated by Joe E. Bandel. Originally published in 1928. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://www.lulu.com/shop/hanns-heinz-ewers-and-joe-e-bandel/fundvogel/paperback/product-v8ygk7y.html

[107] William Faulkner. 2019. *Light in August*. Distributed Proofreaders Canada (Faded Page) eBook 20190624. Originally published in 1932. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://www.fadedpage.com/showbook.php?pid=20190624

[108] Jessie Redmon Fauset. 1929. *Plum Bun: A Novel Without a Moral*. Frederick A. Stokes Company, New York. Lehigh University digital transcription of the 1929 US edition. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://scalar.lehigh.edu/african-american-fiction-a-digital-anthology/jessie-fauset-plum-bun-1929-full-text

[109] Jessie Redmon Fauset. 2026. *There is confusion*. Project Gutenberg eBook 78915. Originally published in 1924. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/78915

[110] Jennifer Fawcett. 2025. *Keep This for Me*. Simon & Schuster. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://www.simonandschuster.net/books/Keep-This-for-Me/Jennifer-Fawcett/9781668050644

[111] Dorothy Canfield Fisher. 2004. *The Bent Twig*. Project Gutenberg eBook 11221. Originally published in 1915. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/11221

[112] Dorothy Canfield Fisher. 2005. *The Brimming Cup*. Project Gutenberg eBook 14957. Originally published in 1921. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/14957

[113] Dorothy Canfield Fisher. 2023. *The home-maker*. Project Gutenberg eBook 72140. Originally published in 1924. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/72140

[114] Antonio Fogazzaro. 2026. *Leila*. Project Gutenberg eBook 78258. Translated by Mary Prichard Agnetti (1911). Originally published in 1910. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/78258

[115] Ford Madox Ford. 2001. *The Good Soldier*. Project Gutenberg eBook 2775. Originally published in 1915. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/2775

[116] Abbigail Forrest. 2021. *These Uncertain Times*. Undergraduate creative thesis. Texas A&M University. p. 34. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://fileserver-az.core.ac.uk/download/479135500.pdf

[117] E. M. Forster. 2001. *A Room with a View*. Project Gutenberg eBook 2641. Originally published in 1908. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/2641

[118] E. M. Forster. 2001. *Howards End*. Project Gutenberg eBook 2891. Originally published in 1910. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/2891

[119] Michelle Frances. 2018. *The Girlfriend*. Kensington Books. Originally published in 2017. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://www.kensingtonbooks.com/shop/the-girlfriend-9781496712486/

[120] Andrea Frazer. 2014. *Bells and Smells*. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://bingebooks.com/book/bells-and-smells

[121] Mary E. Wilkins Freeman. 1891. A New England Nun. In *A New England Nun and Other Stories*. Harper & Brothers. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://en.wikisource.org/wiki/A_New_England_Nun_and_Other_Stories/A_New_England_Nun

[122] Leanne French. n.d. *Libramoor*. Lady Red Web. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://ladyredweb.com/wp-content/uploads/2023/12/libramoor.pdf

[123] Zoe Fuller. 2022. Choices. *Collision Literary Magazine*. Spring 2022 issue. p. 55. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://collision.pitt.edu/wp-content/uploads/2022/08/Collision-Official-2022.pdf

[124] Gina G. 2026. The Interested Party. Reedsy Prompts. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://reedsy.com/short-story/vsvsho/

[125] Zona Gale. 2003. *Miss Lulu Bett*. Project Gutenberg eBook 10429. Originally published in 1920. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/10429

[126] Arnould Galopin. 2015. *The Man With the Blue Face*. Black Coat Press. Translated by Brian Stableford. Originally published in 1907. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://blackcoatpress.com/_iserv/dlfiles/dl.php?ddl=manbluefacechapter.pdf

[127] Gabriel García Márquez. 1995. Sleeping Beauty and the Airplane. In *Bon Voyage, Mr President and Other Stories*. Penguin Books. pp. 32–33. Translated by Edith Grossman. Originally published in 1992. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://openlab.citytech.cuny.edu/hugheseng1121e115spring2016/files/2016/03/Marquez_Sleeping-Beauty.pdf

[128] Elizabeth Gaskell. 2003. *Ruth*. Project Gutenberg eBook 4275. Originally published in 1853. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/4275

[129] Alicia Gaspar de Alba. 2005. *Desert Blood: The Juárez Murders*. Arte Público Press. p. 3. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://artepublicopress.com/wp-content/uploads/2022/04/Desert-Blood.pdf

[130] William Gerhardi. 2025. *Eva's apples*. Project Gutenberg eBook 77377. Originally published in 1928. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/77377

[131] Catherine Gillard. 2018. *The Donor*. Creative-writing thesis. University of Western Australia. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://research-repository.uwa.edu.au/files/33573508/THESIS_MASTER_BY_RESEARCH_GILLARD_Catherine_Louise_2018.pdf

[132] Charlotte Perkins Gilman. 1999. *The Yellow Wallpaper*. Project Gutenberg eBook 1952. Originally published in 1892. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/1952

[133] George Gissing. 1999. *New Grub Street*. Project Gutenberg eBook 1709. Originally published in 1891. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/1709

[134] Ellen Glasgow. 2021. *Barren Ground*. Project Gutenberg eBook 66191. Originally published in 1925. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/66191

[135] Susan Glaspell. 2005. *Lifted Masks; stories*. Project Gutenberg eBook 7368. Includes “Out There”. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/7368

[136] Susan Glaspell. 2010. *Fidelity: A Novel*. Project Gutenberg eBook 32432. Originally published in 1915. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/32432

[137] Maxim Gorky. 2003. *Mother*. Project Gutenberg eBook 3783. Originally published in 1906. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/3783

[138] Anna Katharine Green. 2007. *The Old Stone House and Other Stories*. Project Gutenberg eBook 21824. Includes “A Memorable Night”. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/21824

[139] Sarah P. McLean Greene. 2007. *Vesty of the Basins*. Project Gutenberg eBook 21443. Originally published in 1892. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/21443

[140] Andrew Grey. 2011. *A Troubled Range*. Dreamspinner Press. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://dreamspinnerpress.com/book/a-troubled-range/

[141] Beatrice Grimshaw. 2015. *Vaiti of the Islands*. Project Gutenberg eBook 50663. First serialised in 1906, first published in book form in 1907. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/50663

[142] Dashiell Hammett. 2017. *The Dain Curse*. Distributed Proofreaders Canada (Faded Page) eBook 20170127. Originally published in 1929. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://www.fadedpage.com/showbook.php?pid=20170127

[143] William Alexander Hammond. 1887. *On the Susquehanna*. D. Appleton and Company. p. 122. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://upload.wikimedia.org/wikipedia/commons/6/69/On_the_Susquehanna%3B_a_novel_%28IA_onsusquehannanov00hammiala%29.pdf

[144] Lukas Hartmann. 2022. *Into the Unknown*. Diogenes Verlag. p. 5. Translated by Ruth Martin. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://www.new-books-in-german.com/wp-content/uploads/2022/08/Hartmann_INTO_THE_UNKNOWN_English_sample.pdf

[145] Catherine Hawkins. 2014. Elegantly. In *Creepy and Other Stories*. University of North Carolina Greensboro. p. 25. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://www.digitalgreensboro.org/record/11461/files/td_2407_PDF.pdf

[146] Roger Haydon. 2023. Cold Frame. *Spillwords*. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://spillwords.com/cold-frame/

[147] Zoë Heller. 2008. *The Believers*. Harper Perennial. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://www.bookreporter.com/reviews/the-believers/excerpt

[148] Ernest Hemingway. 2025. *A farewell to arms*. Project Gutenberg eBook 75201. Originally published in 1929. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/75201

[149] G. A. Henty. 2012. *In the Hands of the Malays, and Other Stories*. Project Gutenberg eBook 39616. Includes “On the Track”. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/39616

[150] Michael Hetzer. 1999. *The Forbidden Zone*. Simon & Schuster. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://www.simonandschuster.com/books/The-Forbidden-Zone/Michael-Hetzer/9780684854083

[151] Newell Dwight Hillis. 1913. *The Quest of John Chapman*. The Macmillan Company. Originally published in 1904. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://upload.wikimedia.org/wikipedia/commons/b/bc/The_quest_of_John_Chapman%3B_the_story_of_a_forgotten_hero_%28IA_cu31924055329704%29.pdf

[152] Ian B. Stoughton Holborn. 2016. *The Child of the Moat: A Story for Girls. 1557 A.D.* Project Gutenberg eBook 53281. Originally published in 1916. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/53281

[153] Elisabeth Sanxay Holding. 2022. *The Thing Beyond Reason*. Project Gutenberg eBook 67429. Originally published in 1926. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/67429

[154] Mary Holdsworth. 2012. *Sing a Song of Sixpence*. Project Gutenberg eBook 40154. Originally published in 1892. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/40154

[155] Winifred Holtby. 2022. *The Crowded Street*. Project Gutenberg eBook 68629. Originally published in 1924. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/68629

[156] Thomas Hoover. 2010. *Project Daedalus*. Project Gutenberg eBook 34320. Originally published in 1991. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/34320

[157] E. W. Hornung. 2009. *The Camera Fiend*. Project Gutenberg eBook 30096. Originally published in 1911. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/30096

[158] E. W. Hornung. 2018. *At Large*. Project Gutenberg Australia eBook 1800181. Originally published in 1902. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://gutenberg.net.au/ebooks18/1800181h.html

[159] Anthony Horowitz. 2015. *Trigger Mortis*. Orion. p. 29. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://www.lagardere.com/fichiers/fckeditor/File/Presse/Communique_presse/Livres/Trigger-Mortis-Extract_VGB.pdf

[160] Michel Houellebecq. 2004. *Platform*. Vintage. Translated by Frank Wynne. Vintage paperback ISBN 9781400030262. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://www.readinggroupguides.com/reviews/platform/excerpt

[161] Richard House. 2014. *The Kills*. Picador. p. 28. Originally published in 2013. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://cdn.waterstones.com/special/pdf/9781447261643.pdf

[162] Megan Howell. 2025. The Finger. *The Hopkins Review*. Johns Hopkins University Press. 18(3), Summer 2025. pp. 19–37. https://doi.org/10.1353/thr.2025.a967627. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://muse.jhu.edu/pub/1/article/967627/pdf

[163] W. H. Hudson. 2005. *Fan: The Story of a Young Girl's Life*. Project Gutenberg eBook 7827. Originally published in 1892. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/7827

[164] Langston Hughes. 2024. *Not Without Laughter*. Distributed Proofreaders Canada (Faded Page) eBook 20240413. Originally published in 1930. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://www.fadedpage.com/showbook.php?pid=20240413

[165] Rupert Hughes. 1916. The Thirteenth Commandment. *The Chief*. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://newspapers.swco.ttu.edu/bitstreams/a23aac72-7deb-449a-a637-825f970a2f37/download

[166] Fergus Hume. 2017. *The Wooden Hand: A Detective Story*. Project Gutenberg eBook 55102. Originally published in 1905. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/55102

[167] A. S. M. Hutchinson. 2011. *The Happy Warrior*. Project Gutenberg eBook 38325. Originally published in 1912. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/38325

[168] Aldous Huxley. 1999. *Crome Yellow*. Project Gutenberg eBook 1999. Originally published in 1921. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/1999

[169] Arnaldur Indriðason. 2010. *Arctic Chill*. Picador. Translated by Bernard Scudder and Victoria Cribb. Originally published in 2005. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://us.macmillan.com/books/9780312655303/arcticchill/

[170] Henry James. 2004. *What Maisie Knew*. Project Gutenberg eBook 7118. Originally published in 1897. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/7118

[171] Richard Jefferis. 2023. *Sylvia*. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://richardthewriter.download/101/downloads/Sylvia_by_Richard_Jefferis.pdf

[172] N. K. Jemisin. 2007. The You Train. *Strange Horizons*. December 3, 2007. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://strangehorizons.com/wordpress/fiction/the-you-train/

[173] Pauline Jérémie. 2016. Of Gods and Ghosts. In *From Arthur's Seat 2016*. Egg Box Publishing. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://edwebcontent.ed.ac.uk/sites/default/files/atoms/files/fromarthursseat_2016.pdf

[174] Sarah Orne Jewett. 2008. *The Country of the Pointed Firs*. Project Gutenberg eBook 367. Originally published in 1896. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/367

[175] Mary Johnston. 2005. *Lewis Rand*. Project Gutenberg eBook 14697. Originally published in 1908. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/14697

[176] James Joyce. 2001. *Dubliners*. Project Gutenberg eBook 2814. Originally published in 1914. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/2814

[177] Stephanie Kain. 2020. *Take This Message to the Infants' Ward*. PhD thesis. Lancaster University. p. 188. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://eprints.lancs.ac.uk/id/eprint/141543/1/2020KainPhD.pdf

[178] Clarence Budington Kelland. 2004. *Youth Challenges*. Project Gutenberg eBook 5797. Originally published in 1920. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/5797

[179] Eric P. Kelly. 2024. *The Trumpeter of Krakow: A Tale of the Fifteenth Century*. Project Gutenberg eBook 72600. Originally published in 1928. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/72600

[180] Alan James Keogh. 2013. Work Day. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://alanjameskeogh.wordpress.com/2013/05/22/work-day-short-story/

[181] Kristin Keyes. 2023. I Have No Daughter. *Cowboy Jamboree*. p. 44. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://www.cowboyjamboreemagazine.com/uploads/5/8/6/8/58683251/spring_2023_cjm.pdf

[182] Lee Killough. 1980. A House Divided. In *The Best from Fantasy and Science Fiction: 23rd Series*, edited by Edward L. Ferman. Doubleday. Originally published in 1978. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://s3.us-west-1.wasabisys.com/luminist/EB/F/Ferman_ed%20-%20Best%20from%20F%26SF%2023.pdf

[183] Juhea Kim. 2016. Body Language. *Granta*. July 25, 2016. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://granta.com/body-language/

[184] Liza Klaussmann. 2022. *This is Gonna End in Tears*. John Murray. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://www.hachette.co.uk/wp-content/uploads/2021/11/Bonds_Draft1_8.10.21.pdf

[185] Lynne Kutsukake. 2009. Mating. *The Dalhousie Review*. 89(3). p. 313. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://dalspaceb.library.dal.ca/server/api/core/bitstreams/ca40a49b-df7b-48b8-b8e0-358c6b649da6/content

[186] Selma Lagerlöf. 2005. *Jerusalem*. Project Gutenberg eBook 15837. Translated by Velma Swanston Howard (1915). Originally published in 1901. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/15837

[187] Margarite Landry. 2013. Out of Egypt. *The Baltimore Review*. Spring 2013 issue. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://baltimorereview.org/spring_2013/contributor/margarite-landry

[188] Nella Larsen. 1928. *Quicksand*. Alfred A. Knopf. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://scalar.lehigh.edu/african-american-poetry-a-digital-anthology/nella-larsen-quicksand-1928-full-text--ebook

[189] D. H. Lawrence. 2006. *Sons and Lovers*. Project Gutenberg eBook 217. Originally published in 1913. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/217

[190] Ursula K. Le Guin. 1982. The Eye Altering. In *The Compass Rose*. Berkley Books. Originally published in 1976. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://xenoflesh.wordpress.com/wp-content/uploads/2017/03/guin-ursula-k-le-the-compass-rose_-short-stories.pdf

[191] Rosamond Lehmann. 2024. *Dusty answer*. Project Gutenberg eBook 72642. Originally published in 1927. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/72642

[192] Herb Lehrman. 1966. Revolt of the Potato-Picker. *The Magazine of Fantasy & Science Fiction*. July 1966 issue. p. 100. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://s3.us-west-1.wasabisys.com/luminist/SF/FSF/FSF_1966_07.pdf

[193] Madeleine L'Engle. 2023. *And Both Were Young*. Project Gutenberg eBook 72403. Originally published in 1949. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/72403

[194] Kristen Lepionka. 2018. *What You Want to See*. Minotaur Books. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://us.macmillan.com/books/9781250120540/whatyouwanttosee/

[195] Ada Leverson. 2003. *Tenterhooks*. Project Gutenberg eBook 10021. Originally published in 1912. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/10021

[196] Sinclair Lewis. 2002. *Babbitt*. Project Gutenberg eBook 1156. Originally published in 1922. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/1156

[197] Sinclair Lewis. 2006. *Main Street*. Project Gutenberg eBook 543. Originally published in 1920. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/543

[198] William John Locke. 2005. *Jaffery*. Project Gutenberg eBook 14669. Originally published in 1915. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/14669

[199] Jack London. 1997. *Martin Eden*. Project Gutenberg eBook 1056. Originally published in 1909. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/1056

[200] Anita Loos. 2021. *"Gentlemen prefer blondes"*. Project Gutenberg eBook 66829. Originally published in 1925. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/66829

[201] Edna Lyall. 1999. *Derrick Vaughan, Novelist*. Project Gutenberg eBook 1665. Originally published in 1889. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/1665

[202] Rose Macaulay. 2004. *Potterism: A Tragi-Farcical Tract*. Project Gutenberg eBook 11163. Originally published in 1920. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/11163

[203] Katherine Mansfield. 1998. *The Garden Party, and Other Stories*. Project Gutenberg eBook 1429. Originally published in 1922. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/1429

[204] Katherine Mansfield. 2013. *Bliss, and Other Stories*. Project Gutenberg eBook 44385. Originally published in 1920. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/44385

[205] Scott Mariani. 2016. *The Cassandra Sanction*. Avon. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://fictionbook.ru/trial/txt/42515085.a6.pdf

[206] Richard Marsh. 2011. *Miss Arnott's Marriage*. Project Gutenberg eBook 37963. Originally published in 1904. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/37963

[207] Sarah Beth Martin. 2023. *In the Vanishing Hour*. Encircle Publications. Originally published in 2022. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://www.everand.com/book/688958502/In-the-Vanishing-Hour

[208] Sujata Massey. 2018. *The Widows of Malabar Hill*. Soho Crime. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://www.everand.com/book/770550112/The-Widows-of-Malabar-Hill

[209] Miha Mazzini. 2015. Trains. In *Childhood*. Goga. p. 95. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://www.goga.si/wp-content/uploads/Miha-Mazzini-Childhood.pdf

[210] Kaylin McFarren. 2016. *Banished Threads*. Creative Edge Publishing. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://booklife.com/download-excerpt/binary-data/PROJECT/excerpt/000/012/12122-1.pdf

[211] Claude McKay. 1928. *Home to Harlem*. Harper & Brothers. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://scalar.lehigh.edu/african-american-fiction-a-digital-anthology/claude-mckay-home-to-harlem-full-text-1928

[212] Kevin Moffett. 2025. *Only Son*. McSweeney's. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://lithub.com/only-son/

[213] L. M. Montgomery. 2022. *The Blue Castle: a novel*. Project Gutenberg eBook 67979. Originally published in 1926. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/67979

[214] George Moore. 2005. *Esther Waters*. Project Gutenberg eBook 8157. Originally published in 1894. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/8157

[215] Tomás Q. Morín. 2026. *Cat Love*. Pantheon. p. 9. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://downloads.prh.com/incentives/prd/1771942800/Cat_Love_excerpt.pdf#page=18

[216] William Morrison. 2015. *Shipping Clerk*. Project Gutenberg eBook 50796. Originally published in 1952. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/50796

[217] Catherine Con Morse. 2024. *The Notes*. Random House Children's Books. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://www.rhcbooks.com/books/738182/the-notes-by-catherine-con-morse

[218] Kate Morton. 2020. Caroline's Story; or, Secrets from the Walls of Birchwood Manor. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://www.katemorton.com/carolines-story/

[219] Maryane Myers. 1966. Eyes Behind a Curtain. *Review and Herald*. 143(20), May 19, 1966. p. 9. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://documents.adventistarchives.org/Periodicals/RH/RH19660519-V143-20.pdf

[220] John C. Nash. 2022. *Miss Match's Misadventures*. Obooko. p. 40. Originally published in 2021. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://web.ncf.ca/nashjc/novels/MissMatch.pdf#page=48

[221] E. Nesbit. 1999. *The Railway Children*. Project Gutenberg eBook 1874. Originally published in 1906. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/1874

[222] E. Nesbit. 2002. *The Enchanted Castle*. Project Gutenberg eBook 3536. Originally published in 1907. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/3536

[223] Emily Neville. 2008. *It's Like This, Cat*. Project Gutenberg eBook 24921. Originally published in 1963. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/24921

[224] Yoné Noguchi. 2020. *The American Diary of a Japanese Girl*. Project Gutenberg eBook 63256. Originally published in 1902. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/63256

[225] Charles Gilman Norris. 2021. *Bread*. Project Gutenberg eBook 65944. Originally published in 1923. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/65944

[226] Nikolai Nosov. 1954. *Schoolboys*. Foreign Languages Publishing House. Translated by Rose Prokofieva. Originally published in 1951. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://www.arvindguptatoys.com/arvindgupta/52r.pdf

[227] notestowomen (Adele). 2022. Dushan Learns of Chioma's Visit to Ruth. Notes to Women. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://notestowomen.wordpress.com/2022/06/15/dushan-learns-of-chiomas-visit-to-ruth/

[228] Seán Ó Faoláin. 2017. The Fur Coat. *Vestoj*. Originally published in 1947. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://vestoj.com/the-fur-coat/

[229] Arthur Shattuck O'Keefe. 2018. The Entropy Room. *Ragazine*. May 1, 2018. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://www.ragazine.cc/arthur-shattuck-okeefe-fiction/

[230] Ernest Oldmeadow. 2015. *Susan*. Project Gutenberg eBook 48418. Originally published in 1907. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/48418

[231] E. Phillips Oppenheim. 2010. *The Hillman*. Project Gutenberg eBook 34035. Originally published in 1917. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/34035

[232] Eliza Orzeszkowa. 2007. *The Argonauts*. Project Gutenberg eBook 20537. Translated by Jeremiah Curtin (1901). Originally published in 1899. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/20537

[233] Richard Osman. 2025. *The Impossible Fortune*. Viking. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://cdn.penguin.co.uk/dam-assets/books/9781405975735/9781405975735-sample.pdf

[234] Gustavo Ott. n.d. *Pavlov: Two Seconds before the Crime*. Translated by Heather L. McKay. Spanish text published in 1988. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://gustavoott.com/arc/obrasTrad/15_pavlov-eng-copy.pdf

[235] Ann Packer. 2015. *The Children's Crusade*. Scribner. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://lithub.com/the-childrens-crusade/

[236] Barry Pain. 2011. *Here and Hereafter*. Project Gutenberg eBook 35148. Includes "The Unfinished Game". Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/35148

[237] Francine Pascal. 2004. *The Ruling Class*. Simon & Schuster. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://www.simonandschuster.co.uk/books/The-Ruling-Class/Francine-Pascal/9781442414235

[238] Benito Pérez Galdós. 2006. *Doña Perfecta*. Project Gutenberg eBook 2462. Translated by Mary J. Serrano. Originally published in 1876. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/2462

[239] Virginia Peters. 2008. *In a Cool Blue Light*. MA in Writing manuscript. University of Technology Sydney. p. 124. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://opus.lib.uts.edu.au/bitstream/10453/43649/7/02whole.pdf

[240] David Graham Phillips. 1996. *Susan Lenox: Her Fall and Rise*. Project Gutenberg eBook 450. Originally published in 1917. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/450

[241] Marge Piercy. 2010. *Three Women*. Open Road Integrated Media. Originally published in 1999. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://www.everand.com/book/714895477/Three-Women-A-Novel

[242] Margaret Rebecca Piper. 2015. *Sylvia Arden Decides*. Project Gutenberg eBook 48385. Originally published in 1917. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/48385

[243] Melville Davisson Post. 2004. Five Thousand Dollars Reward. In *O. Henry Memorial Award Prize Stories of 1919*, edited by Blanche Colton Williams. Project Gutenberg eBook 12094. Story first published in 1919. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/12094

[244] David Pratt. 2023. Damaging Admissions. *Tenth Muse*. Volume XIII. pp. 28–29. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://lsbassen.com/wp-content/uploads/2023/07/ee51d-tm-volumexiii-2023altsmol.pdf

[245] J. B. Priestley. 2026. *Angel Pavement*. Project Gutenberg eBook 78329. Originally published in 1930. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/78329

[246] Xenobe Purvis. 2025. *The Hounding*. Farrar, Straus and Giroux. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://us.macmillan.com/books/9781250366405/thehounding/

[247] Forrest Reid. 2025. *Following darkness*. Project Gutenberg eBook 75675. Originally published in 1912. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/75675

[248] Nan Reinhardt. 2024. *Make You Mine*. Tule Publishing. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://tulepublishing.com/books/make-you-mine/

[249] Alice Hegan Rice. 2006. *Quin*. Project Gutenberg eBook 20033. Originally published in 1921. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/20033

[250] Craig Rice. 1954. Murder in the Family. *The Saint Detective Magazine*. November 1954 issue. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://electronicsandbooks.com/edt/manual/Old%20Pulp%20Magazines/%21%20new/Saint%20-%20November%201954.pdf

[251] Laura E. Richards. 2008. *Peggy*. Project Gutenberg eBook 25448. Originally published in 1899. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/25448

[252] Dorothy M. Richardson. 2002. *Pointed roofs*. Project Gutenberg eBook 3019. Originally published in 1915. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/3019

[253] Dorothy M. Richardson. 2018. *The tunnel*. Project Gutenberg eBook 56447. Originally published in 1919. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/56447

[254] Mary Roberts Rinehart and Avery Hopwood. 2000. *The Bat*. Project Gutenberg eBook 2019. Originally published in 1926. Novel adaptation by Stephen Vincent Benét. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/2019

[255] Michael James Rizza. 2012. Anonymous. *Switchback*. Issue 15, Spring 2012, part V. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://cpb-us-w2.wpmucdn.com/usfblogs.usfca.edu/dist/e/1018/files/2020/07/Switchback-issue15-spring2012.pdf

[256] Nora Roberts. 2001. *Dance Upon the Air*. Jove Books. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://penguinrandomhouselibrary.com/book/?isbn=9780515131222

[257] C. D. Rose. 2024. Ognosia. In *Walter Benjamin Stares at the Sea*. Melville House. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://prhinternationalsales.com/book/?isbn=9781685890841

[258] Léna Roy. 2010. *Edges*. Farrar, Straus and Giroux. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://www.abebooks.com/9780374350529/Edges-Roy-L%C3%A9na-0374350523/plp?cm_sp=plped-_-1-_-image

[259] Nadia Steven Rysing. 2024. *Wilder Creatures*. Undertaker Books. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://www.everand.com/book/784310359/Wilder-Creatures

[260] Angie Sage. 2005. *Magyk*. HarperCollins. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://www.bookbrowse.com/excerpts/index.cfm/book_number/1548/page_number/5/magyk

[261] Saki. 1998. *The Toys of Peace, and Other Papers*. Project Gutenberg eBook 1477. Includes “Bertie’s Christmas Eve”. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/1477

[262] Shannon Sanders. 2020. Mote. *Joyland*. Volume X. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://joylandpublishing.com/fiction/mote/

[263] Patricia Scanlan. 2016. *Apartment 3B*. Atria Books. Originally published in 1991. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://parents.simonandschuster.com/9781501134562

[264] Salvatore Scibona. 2019. *The Volunteer*. Penguin Books. p. 11. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://cdn.penguin.co.uk/dam-assets/books/9781784708481/9781784708481-sample.pdf

[265] Briana Scott and Carl H. Thompson. 2012. *Jasmine Absolute*. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://www.independentauthornetwork.com/uploads/3/9/7/9/3979996/excerpt_from_jasmine_absolute.pdf

[266] Rebecca Serle. 2018. *The Dinner List*. Flatiron Books. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://us.macmillan.com/books/9781250295200/thedinnerlist/

[267] Anna Lidia Vega Serova. 2021. The Eclipse. *The Common*. Translated by Jennifer Shyue. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://www.thecommononline.org/the-eclipse/

[268] Peggy Shane. 1934. Tangled Wives. *The Times (Willamina, Oregon)*. p. 6. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://oregonnews.uoregon.edu/lccn/2025240345/1934-02-01/ed-1/seq-6.pdf

[269] Robert Sheckley. n.d. *Dimension of Miracles*. Originally published in 1968. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://avalonlibrary.net/ebooks/Robert%20Sheckley%20-%20Dimension%20of%20Miracles.pdf

[270] Wendy Sheehan. 2025. Nellie and June and Little Davy Crockett. *Kaleidoscope*. Issue 91, Summer/Fall 2025. p. 44. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://www.udsakron.org/wp-content/uploads/K91-FINAL-with-links-COMPRESSED.pdf

[271] Nevil Shute. 2014. *Trustee from the Toolroom*. Distributed Proofreaders Canada (Faded Page) eBook 20140417. Originally published in 1960. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://www.fadedpage.com/showbook.php?pid=20140417

[272] Laura Simmons. 2015. *Little Bits of Karma*. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://booklife.com/download-excerpt/binary-data/PROJECT/excerpt/000/013/13545-1.pdf

[273] Helen Simpson. 2018. Moscow. In *Cockfosters*. Vintage. Collection first published in 2015. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://www.penguinrandomhouseretail.com/book/?isbn=9780525563624

[274] May Sinclair. 2005. *Life and Death of Harriett Frean*. Project Gutenberg eBook 9298. Originally published in 1922. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/9298

[275] Domenico Starnone. 2025. Diseducators. *The Atlantic*. Translated by Oonagh Stransky. Excerpt from *La Scuola* (2022). Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://www.theatlantic.com/books/2025/09/domenico-starnone-diseducators-short-story/684246/

[276] Harriet Beecher Stowe. 2006. *Uncle Tom's Cabin*. Project Gutenberg eBook 203. Originally published in 1852. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/203

[277] Harriet Beecher Stowe. 2015. *We and Our Neighbors; or, The Records of an Unfashionable Street*. Project Gutenberg eBook 48603. Originally published in 1875. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/48603

[278] Joe Stretch. 2025. Malandrino. *Granta*. January 10, 2025. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://granta.com/malandrino/

[279] Ruth Suckow. 2025. *The John Wood Case*. Distributed Proofreaders Canada (Faded Page) eBook 20250218. Originally published in 1959. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://www.fadedpage.com/showbook.php?pid=20250218

[280] Sun Pin. 2022. Balcony. *The World of Chinese*. Translated by Jesse Young. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://www.theworldofchinese.com/2022/01/balcony-fiction/

[281] Booth Tarkington. 2021. *Women*. Project Gutenberg eBook 65207. Includes “Perversity of a Telephone”. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/65207

[282] Mary Imlay Taylor. 2024. *The long way*. Project Gutenberg eBook 73867. Originally published in 1913. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/73867

[283] Josephine Tey. 2008. *The Franchise Affair*. Distributed Proofreaders Canada (Faded Page) eBook 20080213. Originally published in 1948. Based on *Three by Tey*, 1954 omnibus, seventh printing, 1968. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://www.fadedpage.com/showbook.php?pid=20080213

[284] Andrea Thalasinos. 2014. *Traveling Light*. Forge Books. Originally published in 2013. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://us.macmillan.com/books/9780765337788/travelinglight/

[285] E. Temple Thurston. 2013. *The Green Bough*. Project Gutenberg eBook 41895. Originally published in 1921. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/41895

[286] Lavie Tidhar. 2024. Judge Dee and the Executioner of Epinal. *Reactor*. April 17, 2024. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://reactormag.com/judge-dee-and-the-executioner-of-epinal-lavie-tidhar/

[287] Jessica Tom. 2015. *Food Whore: A Novel of Dining and Deceit*. St. Martin’s Griffin. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://www.readinggroupguides.com/reviews/food-whore-a-novel-of-dining-and-deceit/excerpt

[288] Nichelle D. Tramble. 2004. *The Last King*. Strivers Row/Ballantine Books. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://books.google.com/books?id=7viJR5_o6aMC

[289] Nola Turkington. n.d. The Truth Tree. *Nal’ibali supplement*. PRAESA and Avusa Education. Edition 7. Adapted from *Stories that Talk* (Heartlines, 2006). Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://nalibali.org/wp-content/uploads/2025/07/unnamed-file-648.pdf

[290] Sheila Turnage. 2023. *Island of Spies*. Dial Books. Originally published in 2022. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://www.penguinrandomhouseretail.com/book/?isbn=9780735231276

[291] Oles Ulianenko. 2021. Stalinka. *Ukrainian Literature: A Journal of Translation*. Volume 6, part II. p. 175. Translated by Olha Rudakevych. Originally published in 1994. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://tarnawsky.artsci.utoronto.ca/elul/Ukr_Lit/Vol06/Whole-Ukr-Lit-6-2021.pdf

[292] Sigrid Undset. 2019. *Jenny: A Novel*. Project Gutenberg eBook 60741. Translated by William Emmé (1921). Originally published in 1911. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/60741

[293] Ken Untiedt. 2023. *What We Need*. Next Stage Press. p. 27. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://www.nextstagepress.com/wp-content/uploads/2024/01/What-We-Need-Sample.pdf

[294] S. S. Van Dine. 2023. *The Benson Murder Case*. Project Gutenberg eBook 70634. Originally published in 1926. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/70634

[295] Emma M. Venables. 2017. The Photograph. *Litro*. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://www.litromagazine.com/story-sunday/the-photograph/

[296] Edgar Wallace. 2023. *The Avenger*. Project Gutenberg eBook 69788. Originally published in 1926. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/69788

[297] Sylvia Townsend Warner. 2023. *Lolly Willowes*. Project Gutenberg eBook 72223. Originally published in 1926. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/72223

[298] Frank V. Webster. 2011. *The Boys of the Wireless; Or, A Stirring Rescue from the Deep*. Project Gutenberg eBook 35044. Originally published in 1912. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/35044

[299] Henry Kitchell Webster. 1924. Joseph Greer and His Daughter. *Sanderson Times*. Originally published in 1922. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://newspapers.swco.ttu.edu/bitstreams/4d561df9-b404-4c8c-9dfb-747beec0f19a/download

[300] H. G. Wells. 2004. *Love and Mr. Lewisham*. Project Gutenberg eBook 11640. Originally published in 1900. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/11640

[301] H. G. Wells. 2004. *The Sleeper Awakes*. Project Gutenberg eBook 12163. Originally published in 1910. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/12163

[302] H. G. Wells. 2009. *Select Conversations with an Uncle (Now Extinct) and Two Other Reminiscences*. Project Gutenberg eBook 29472. Originally published in 1895. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/29472

[303] H. G. Wells. 2013. *Meanwhile: The Picture of a Lady*. Project Gutenberg Australia eBook 1303271. Originally published in 1927. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://gutenberg.net.au/ebooks13/1303271h.html

[304] Edith Wharton. 1995. *The House of Mirth*. Project Gutenberg eBook 284. Originally published in 1905. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/284

[305] Edith Wharton. 1996. *The Age of Innocence*. Project Gutenberg eBook 541. Originally published in 1920. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/541

[306] Edith Wharton. 1998. *The Glimpses of the Moon*. Project Gutenberg eBook 1263. Originally published in 1922. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/1263

[307] Edith Wharton. 2004. *The Custom of the Country*. Project Gutenberg eBook 11052. Originally published in 1913. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/11052

[308] Edith Wharton. 2006. *Summer*. Project Gutenberg eBook 166. Originally published in 1917. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/166

[309] Dorothy Whipple. 2026. *Because of the Lockwoods*. Distributed Proofreaders Canada (Faded Page) eBook 20260426. Originally published in 1949. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://www.fadedpage.com/showbook.php?pid=20260426

[310] Fred M. White. 2014. *In Trust*. Project Gutenberg Australia eBook 1402531. Originally published in 1892. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://gutenberg.net.au/ebooks14/1402531h.html

[311] Christina Gowans Whyte. 2013. *The Story Book Girls*. Project Gutenberg eBook 41797. Originally published in 1906. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/41797

[312] Jasmine Wilborne. 2010. Marlie. *Folio*. Southern Connecticut State University. 2010 issue. p. 33. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://www.southernct.edu/sites/default/files/a/sites/folio/Folio-2010.pdf

[313] Frances Mensah Williams. 2023. Lucky Ship. *My Weekly*. March 2023 issue. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://francesmensahwilliams.com/wp-content/uploads/2023/05/Lucky_Ship_My_Weekly_Magazine_March_2023.pdf

[314] Margery Williams. 2004. *The Velveteen Rabbit*. Project Gutenberg eBook 11757. Originally published in 1922. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/11757

[315] Pip Williams. 2021. The Dictionary of Lost Words. In *Spring 2021 Debut Fiction Sampler*. Penguin Random House Library Marketing. p. 173. Originally published in 2020. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://penguinrandomhouselibrary.com/wp-content/uploads/2026/04/Debut-Fiction-Sampler_Spring-21_.pdf

[316] Tennessee Williams. n.d. *A Streetcar Named Desire*. Pearson teaching-materials reproduction. Originally published in 1947. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://qualifications.pearson.com/content/dam/pdf/A%20Level/English%20Language%20and%20Literature/2015/teaching-and-learning-materials/9EL0_01_COLLATION.pdf

[317] Josephine Wilson. 2013. *Extinctions*. Dissertation. University of Western Australia. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://research-repository.uwa.edu.au/files/9890028/Wilson_Josephine_2013.pdf

[318] William James Wintle. 2016. *Ghost Gleams: Tales of the Uncanny*. Project Gutenberg Australia eBook 1600771. Includes “The House on the Cliff”. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://gutenberg.net.au/ebooks16/1600771h.html

[319] P. G. Wodehouse. 1999. *Piccadilly Jim*. Project Gutenberg eBook 2005. Originally published in 1917. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/2005

[320] P. G. Wodehouse. 2004. *A Prefect's Uncle*. Project Gutenberg eBook 6985. Originally published in 1902. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/6985

[321] P. G. Wodehouse. 2023. *The Small Bachelor*. Project Gutenberg eBook 70041. Originally published in 1927. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/70041

[322] Ellen Wood. 2012. *Mildred Arkell: A Novel. Vol. 2 (of 3)*. Project Gutenberg eBook 39377. Originally published in 1865. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/39377

[323] Virginia Woolf. 1998. *Night and Day*. Project Gutenberg eBook 1245. Originally published in 1919. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/1245

[324] Virginia Woolf. 2004. *Jacob's Room*. Project Gutenberg eBook 5670. Originally published in 1922. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/5670

[325] Virginia Woolf. 2006. *The Voyage Out*. Project Gutenberg eBook 144. Originally published in 1915. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/144

[326] Virginia Woolf. 2023. *Mrs. Dalloway*. Project Gutenberg eBook 71865. Originally published in 1925. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/71865

[327] Anzia Yezierska. 2012. *Hungry Hearts*. Project Gutenberg eBook 41232. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/41232

[328] E. H. Young. 2023. *Miss Mole*. Distributed Proofreaders Canada (Faded Page) eBook 20230217. Originally published in 1930. Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://www.fadedpage.com/showbook.php?pid=20230217

[329] Anne Youngson. 2021. *The Narrowboat Summer*. Flatiron Books. First published in the UK as *Three Women and a Boat* (2020). Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://us.macmillan.com/books/9781250764621/thenarrowboatsummer/

[330] Émile Zola. 2006. *Four Short Stories by Émile Zola*. Project Gutenberg eBook 1069. Includes an excerpt from *Nana* (1880). Retrieved November 5, 2026 from https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/1069

[331] Leo Tolstoy. 1886. *The Death of Ivan Ilych*. Chapter IV. English translation reproduced on Wikisource. Retrieved November 6, 2026 from https://en.wikisource.org/wiki/The_Death_of_Ivan_Ilych/IV

[332] Cancer Research UK. 2026. Stage 4 pancreatic cancer. Last reviewed August 20, 2026. Retrieved November 6, 2026 from https://www.cancerresearchuk.org/about-cancer/pancreatic-cancer/stages-types-grades/stage-4

[333] National Cancer Institute. 2026. Pancreatic Cancer Stages. Posted July 30, 2026. Retrieved November 6, 2026 from https://www.cancer.gov/types/pancreatic/stages

[334] Katherine Anne Brown. 2009. *Treading Water*. MA (Writing) novel. University of the Witwatersrand, Johannesburg, p. 36. Retrieved November 6, 2026 from https://wiredspace.wits.ac.za/server/api/core/bitstreams/dc70dba9-74bb-4ff7-9174-3b8d3c4fb3a8/content

[335] A. A. Caffrey. 1939. Spy Scare at Federal. *Short Stories* (August 10, 1939), p. 125. Retrieved November 6, 2026 from https://electronicsandbooks.com/edt/manual/Old%20Pulp%20Magazines/%21%20new/Short%20Stories%2B%20-%2010%20August%201939.pdf

[336] Orson Scott Card. n.d. *Ender's Game*. Classroom PDF reproduction, chapter 9. School District 79 (Cowichan Valley). Novel first published by Tor Books in 1985. Retrieved November 6, 2026 from https://moodle.sd79.bc.ca/pluginfile.php/83276/mod_book/chapter/39236/Enders%20Game%20PDF.pdf

[337] Ann Darby. 2012. *The Orphan Game*. HarperCollins-authorised excerpt on Bookreporter.com, chapter 1. Originally published in 1999. Retrieved November 6, 2026 from https://www.bookreporter.com/reviews/the-orphan-game/excerpt

[338] Halina Duraj. 2024. I'll Love You Again Tomorrow. *Catamaran Literary Reader*, Winter 2024. Retrieved November 6, 2026 from https://catamaranliteraryreader.com/s/Halina-Duraj-22Ill-ove-You-Again-Tomorrow22.pdf

[339] Gabriel García Márquez. n.d. Tuesday Siesta. Bilingual reproduction edited by Miguel Garci-Gomez. Duke University. Spanish original published in 1962. Retrieved November 6, 2026 from https://people.duke.edu/~garci/cibertextos/bilingues/GARCIA-MARQUEZ-G/CUENTOS/SIESTA-MARTES.HTM

[340] Elly Griffiths. 2021. *The Postscript Murders: A Mystery*. Houghton Mifflin Harcourt. First U.S. ebook edition, ISBN 9780358419181. Originally published in the UK in 2020. Retrieved November 6, 2026 from https://www.everand.com/book/623628986/The-Postscript-Murders-A-Mystery

[341] Anna Hope. 2015. *Wake*. Black Swan, London. First published in 2014. p. 146. Retrieved November 6, 2026 from https://cdn.waterstones.com/special/pdf/9780552779463.pdf

[342] Hannah Jayne. 2016. *Twisted*. Sourcebooks Fire. Licensed ebook excerpt, chapter 2. Retrieved November 6, 2026 from https://www.everand.com/book/316377395/Twisted

[343] Jac Jemc. 2019. Any Other. In *False Bingo: Stories*. MCD × FSG Originals, New York. Retrieved November 6, 2026 from https://us.macmillan.com/books/9780374720421/falsebingo/

[344] Hiromi Kawakami. 2018. Parfait. *Granta* (August 31, 2018). Excerpt from *The Ten Loves of Mr Nishino*. Translated by Allison Markin Powell. Retrieved November 6, 2026 from https://granta.com/parfait/

[345] Tom Kristensen. 2018. *Havoc*. Translated by Carl Malmberg. NYRB Classics, New York. Originally published in Danish in 1930. Retrieved November 6, 2026 from https://www.everand.com/book/770589873/Havoc

[346] Charles Godfrey Leland. 2025. *Flaxius: Leaves from the Life of an Immortal*. Project Gutenberg eBook 77376. Originally published by Philip Wellby, London, in 1902. Retrieved November 6, 2026 from https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/77376

[347] Julie Diane Mellor. 2003. *Cork Dolls*. Novel in *Theorising Contemporary Women's Writing: A Practice-based Study*, volume 1. PhD thesis, Sheffield Hallam University, p. 232. Retrieved November 6, 2026 from https://shura.shu.ac.uk/20759/1/10702858.pdf

[348] Marise Morland. 1982. Trojan Horse. *Practical Computing* 5, 3 (March 1982). IPC Business Press. Retrieved November 6, 2026 from https://www.worldradiohistory.com/UK/Practical-Computing/80s/Practical-Computing-1982-03-S-OCR.pdf

[349] Marlene Perez. 2013. *Dead Is Just a Dream*. HMH Books for Young Readers. Excerpt on Bookreporter.com. Retrieved November 6, 2026 from https://www.bookreporter.com/reviews/dead-is-just-a-dream/excerpt

[350] Mark Andrew Poe. 2018. *Snow Day*. Harry Moon series. Rabbit Publishers, Arlington Heights, IL. Retrieved November 6, 2026 from https://www.state.lib.la.us/files/HarryMoon/HarryMoon_SNOW_DAY_eBook.pdf

[351] Ashley Poston. 2023. *The Seven Year Slip*. Berkley, New York. Retrieved November 6, 2026 from https://www.everand.com/book/768004585/The-Seven-Year-Slip

[352] Thomas Pynchon. 2015. *Inherent Vice*. Vintage, London, p. 39. Film tie-in edition, ISBN 9781784700416. Originally published in 2009. Retrieved November 6, 2026 from https://cdn.waterstones.com/special/pdf/9781784700416.pdf

[353] Leslie Marmon Silko. 2008. Storyteller. In *Reckonings: Contemporary Short Fiction by Native American Women*, edited by Hertha D. Sweet Wong, Lauren Stuart Muller and Jana Sequoya Magdaleno. Oxford University Press, New York, 131–142. Originally published in 1981. Retrieved November 6, 2026 from https://paas.org.pl/wp-content/uploads/2016/09/Reckonings__Contemporary_Short_Fiction_by_Native_American_Women.pdf

[354] J. Courtney Sullivan. 2011. *Maine*. Alfred A. Knopf. Authorised excerpt on ReadingGroupGuides.com. Retrieved November 6, 2026 from https://www.readinggroupguides.com/reviews/maine/excerpt

[355] Skye Sweven. n.d. *Elysia: The Wasteworld*. Author preview, chapter 3, “The Desert.” BookLife. Retrieved November 6, 2026 from https://booklife.com/download-excerpt/binary-data/PROJECT/excerpt/000/037/37359-1.pdf

[356] Anne Tyler. 2016. *Vinegar Girl*. Hogarth Shakespeare. Authorised excerpt in *Literary Hub*. Retrieved November 6, 2026 from https://lithub.com/vinegar-girl/

[357] Zakia Uddin. 2021. Signal. *Granta*, The Online Edition (December 16, 2021). Retrieved November 6, 2026 from https://granta.com/signal/

[358] Arturo Vivante. 1966. The Room. *The New Yorker* (July 30, 1966). Retrieved November 6, 2026 from https://www.newyorker.com/magazine/1966/07/30/the-room-2

[359] Sanford R. Wilbur. n.d. Keeping the Music Playing. Author's online presentation of an episode from *Vic and Greg: A Wildlife Refuge Romance* (Symbios, 2024). Retrieved November 6, 2026 from https://www.writing-it-down.com/little-romances/keeping-the-music-playing.html

[360] Gretchen Felker-Martin. 2024. *Cuckoo*. Tor Nightfire. Publisher excerpt. Retrieved November 6, 2026 from https://us.macmillan.com/books/9781250794666/cuckoo/

[361] Jo Mary Elizabeth Dutton. 2018. *Wrecked*. Novel in master's thesis, The University of Western Australia, p. 162. Retrieved November 6, 2026 from https://api.research-repository.uwa.edu.au/ws/portalfiles/portal/37051379/THESIS_MASTER_BY_RESEARCH_DUTTON_Jo_Mary_Elizabeth_2018.pdf